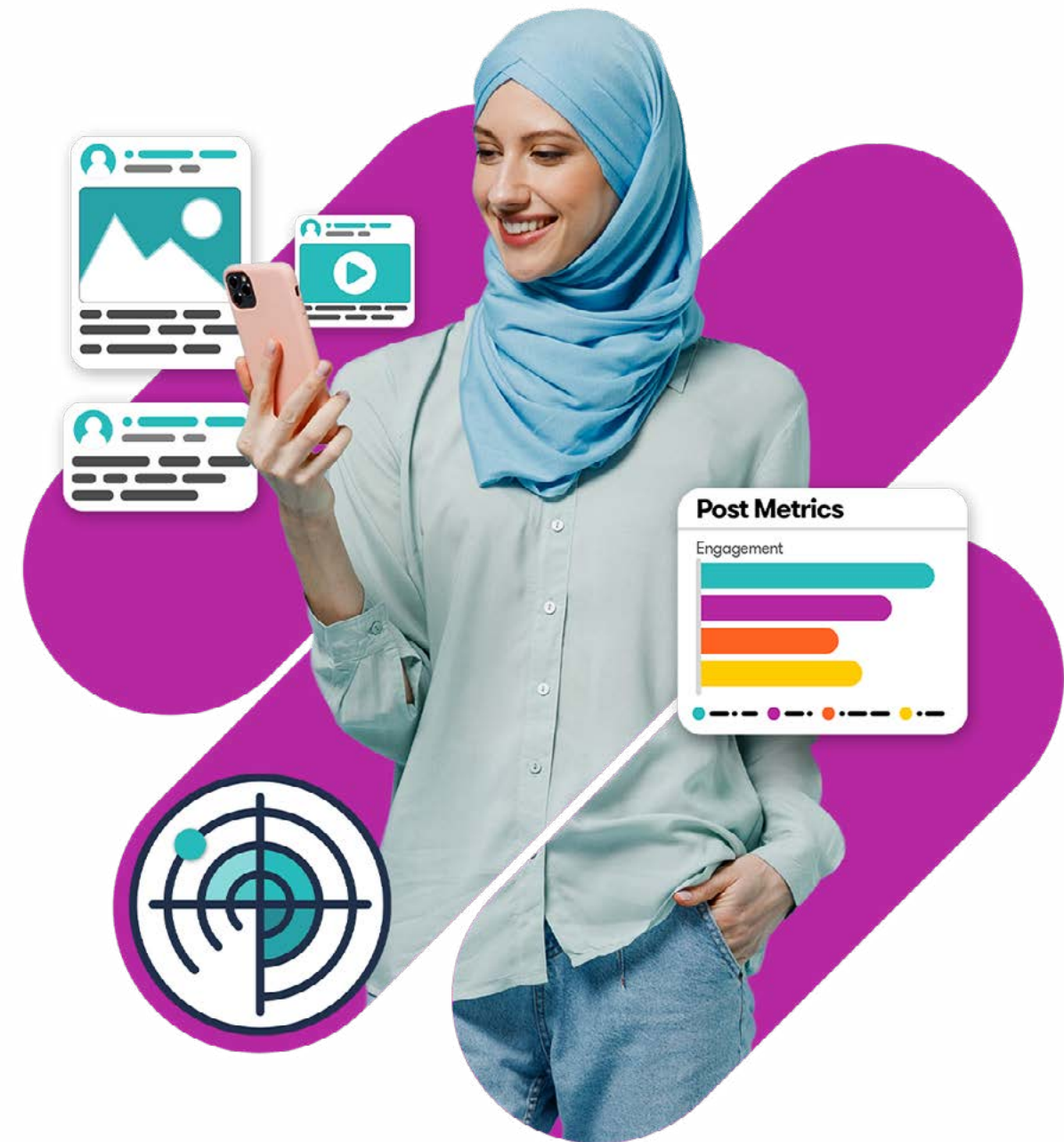


State of Social Media 2026

Europe, Middle
East, Africa, Region



Introduction

The digital landscape continues to undergo changes with the proliferation of AI, and social media is along for the ride. But even with the constant flux and rapid transition, social media use continues to steadily rise, reaching [5.66 billion in 2025](#) — a 4.8% increase year over year.

This means businesses must know how to react. Not only because your 22-year-old intern is insisting on it, but because if you don't, you're leaving money on the table. [72% of internet users use social media for brand research](#). That's a lot of purchase power among those growing online audiences.

Meltwater's annual State of Social Media Report aims to identify the trends that will help you formulate a strategic, data-backed plan of attack for 2026. This particular report looks at region-specific trends across Europe, the Middle East, and Africa (EMEA) based on survey responses from over 400 marketing professionals.

Learn where your peers are focused, what goals to prioritize, which channels offer previously unmet opportunities, and keep adapting to shifting online behaviors in a deliberate and intentional way.



Contents

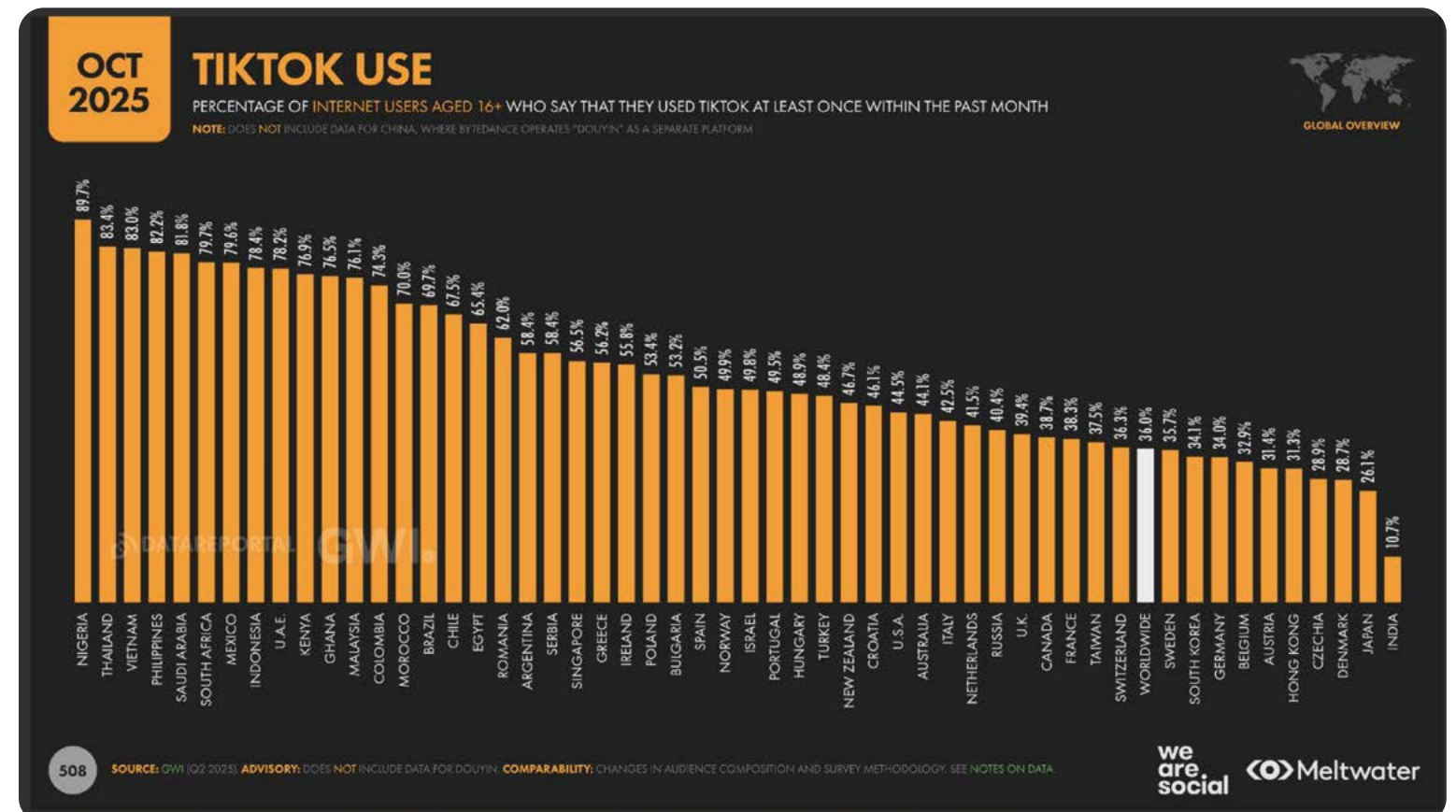
02	Introduction	30	Survey Results: Social Listening
04	Survey Coverage	39	Survey Results: Paid Social
06	Company Type & Role Breakdown	43	Meet Meltwater
10	Survey Results: Organic Social Media		

Survey Coverage

We gathered 430+ responses from companies in the EMEA region, covering a wide range of countries including Germany, France, the Netherlands, Portugal, Kenya, South Africa, Turkey, the UAE, and more.

Social Media Usage Worldwide

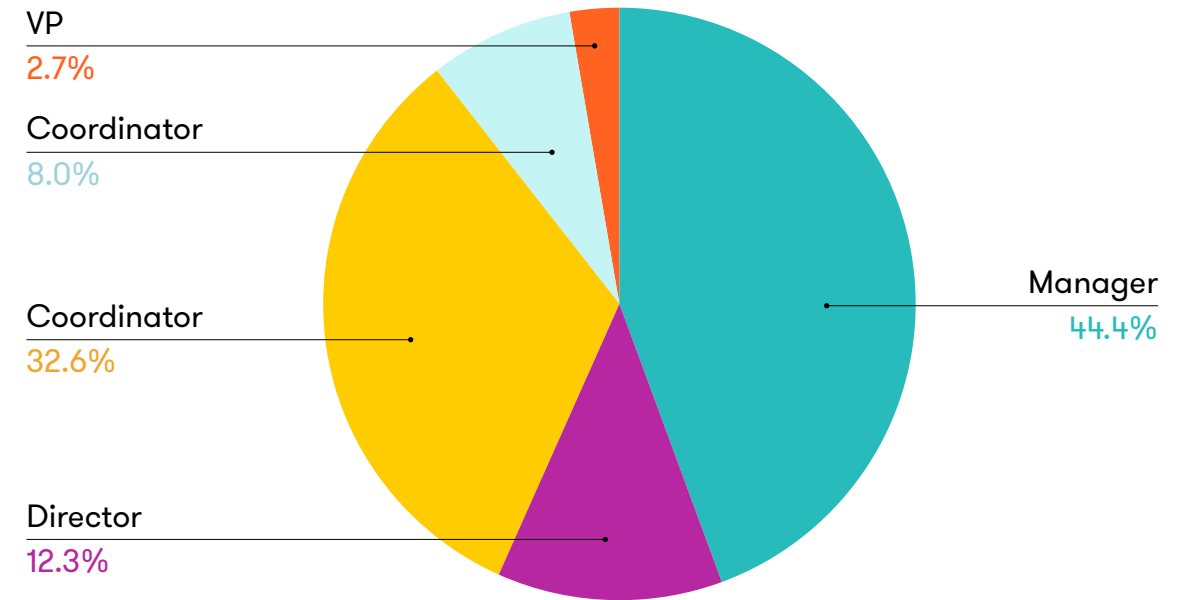
The State of Social Media Report looks at how companies are approaching their social media programs, but it's crucial to also be aware of how user behavior is changing. The [Global Digital Report](#), published by Kepios in partnership with We Are Social, is your go-to resource, covering social media and digital trends in detail (600+ pages of data!). Some relevant facts from the report are included in this State of Social Media report, but we encourage you to download the Global Digital Report where you can gather even more context, applicable to your specific use-cases, needs, and interests.



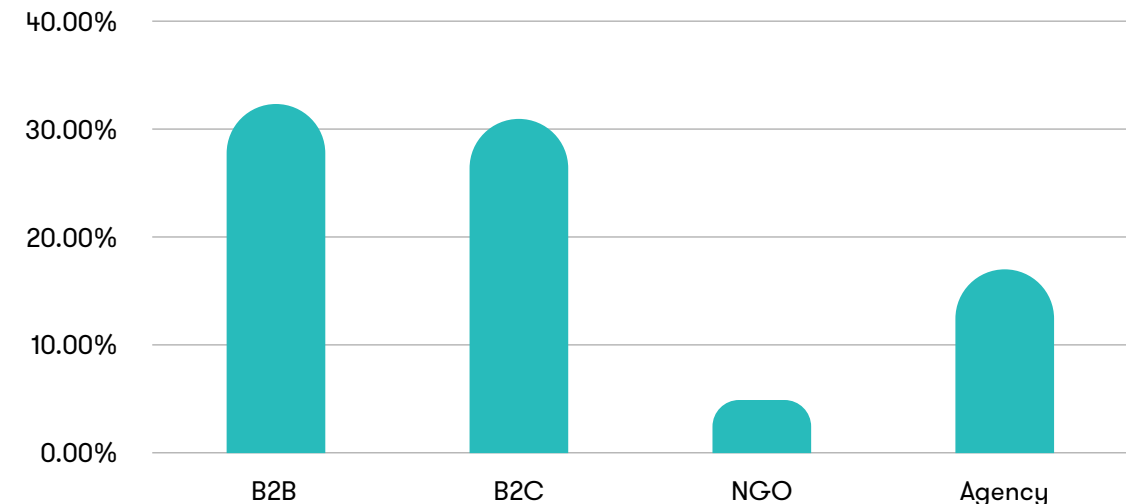
Company Type & Role Breakdown

Responses came from a range of company types and a variety of seniority levels, with B2B companies narrowly edging out B2C, a shift from the previous year where B2B was far more prevalent. This is also in contrast to our [Americas regional report](#) and our [Global report](#) this year, where B2C responses far outweighed B2B. Agency responses increased for EMEA as well, with an 18% uptick. Most respondents work in a Manager or Coordinator role.

What is your job level?



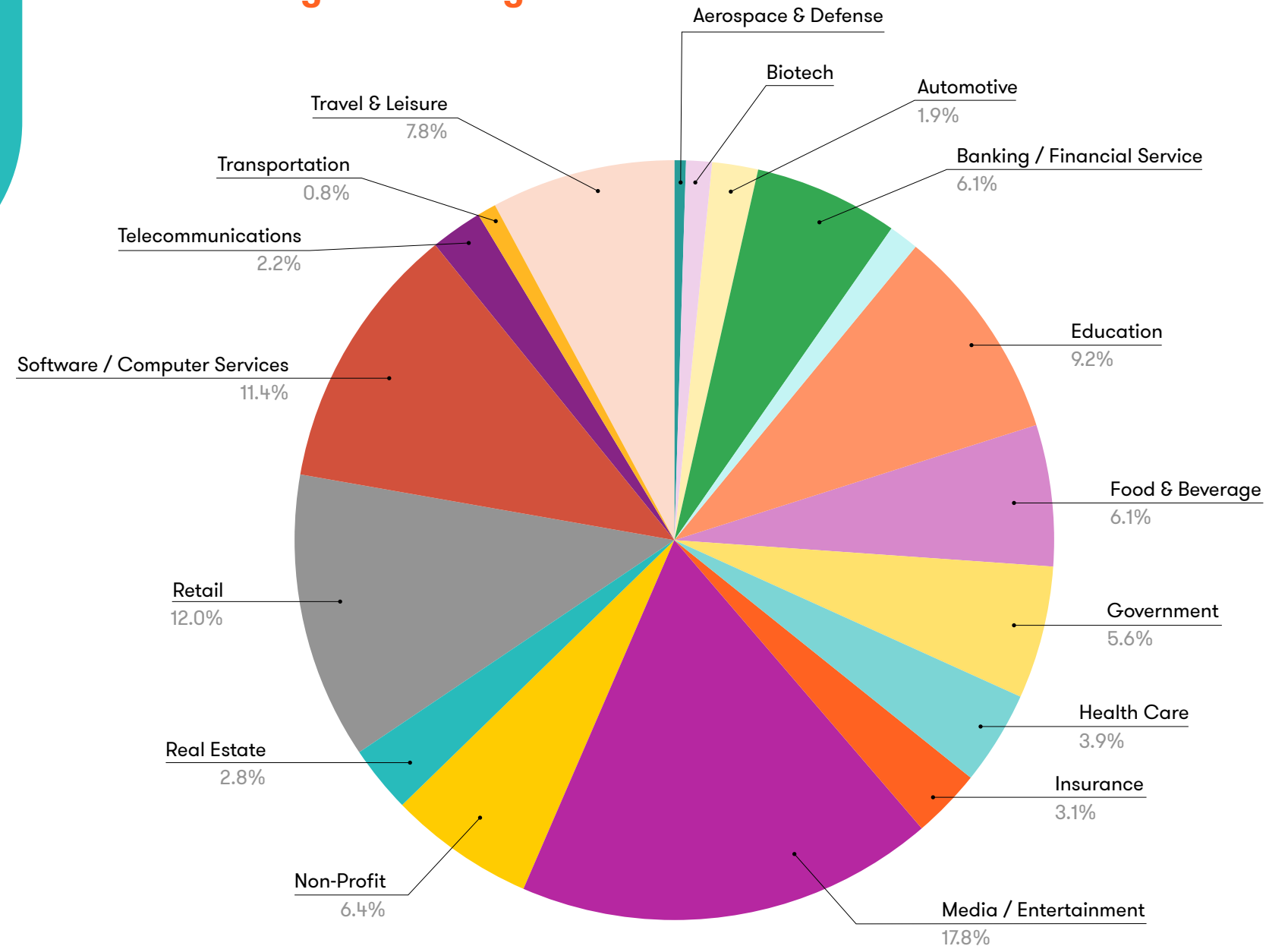
What best describes the type of organization you work for?



Industry

In a new addition to this year's survey, we asked respondents what best describes their industry. Responses show a wide variety, with the majority coming from Entertainment, Retail, and Software.

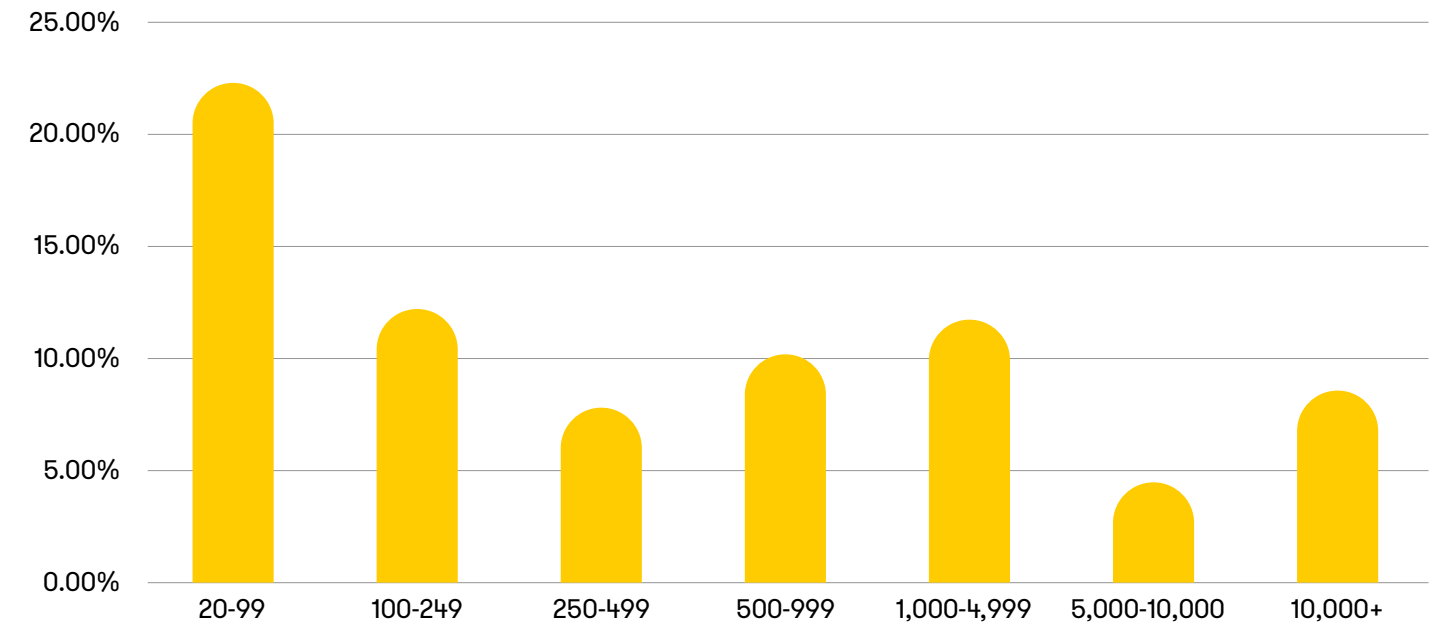
What is your industry?



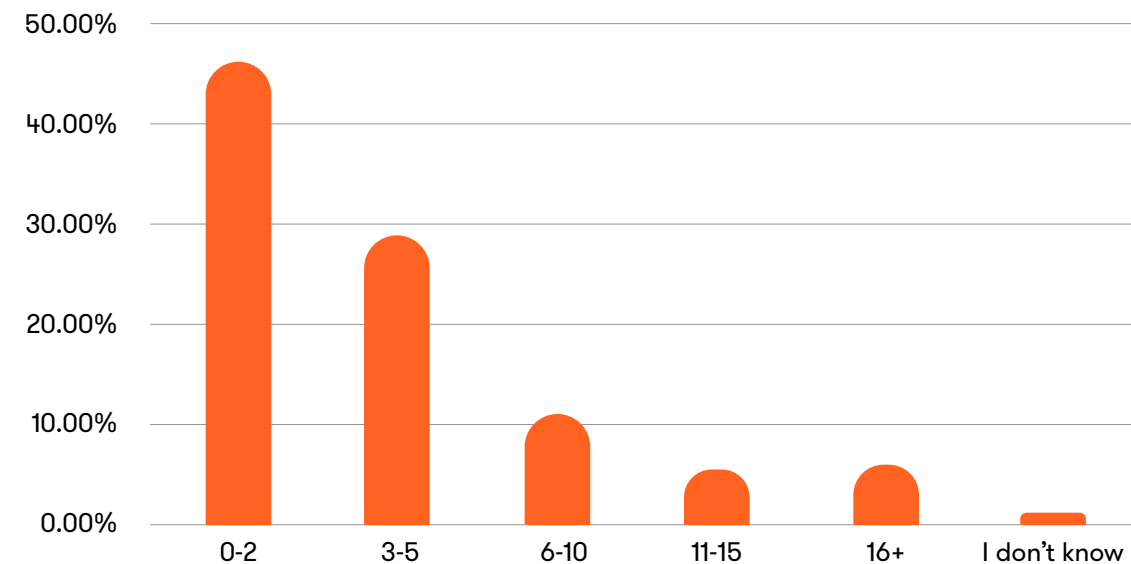
Social Media Team Size

While respondents' company sizes varied, the majority of survey respondents are operating with small social media teams (0-2 members). While this limited bandwidth is consistent with last year's findings, it should be noted that a higher number of organizations say they are operating with a more advanced social program year over year. See page 11 for more!

How many employees does your company have?



How many people work in social media at your company?



Optimize your impact with social listening

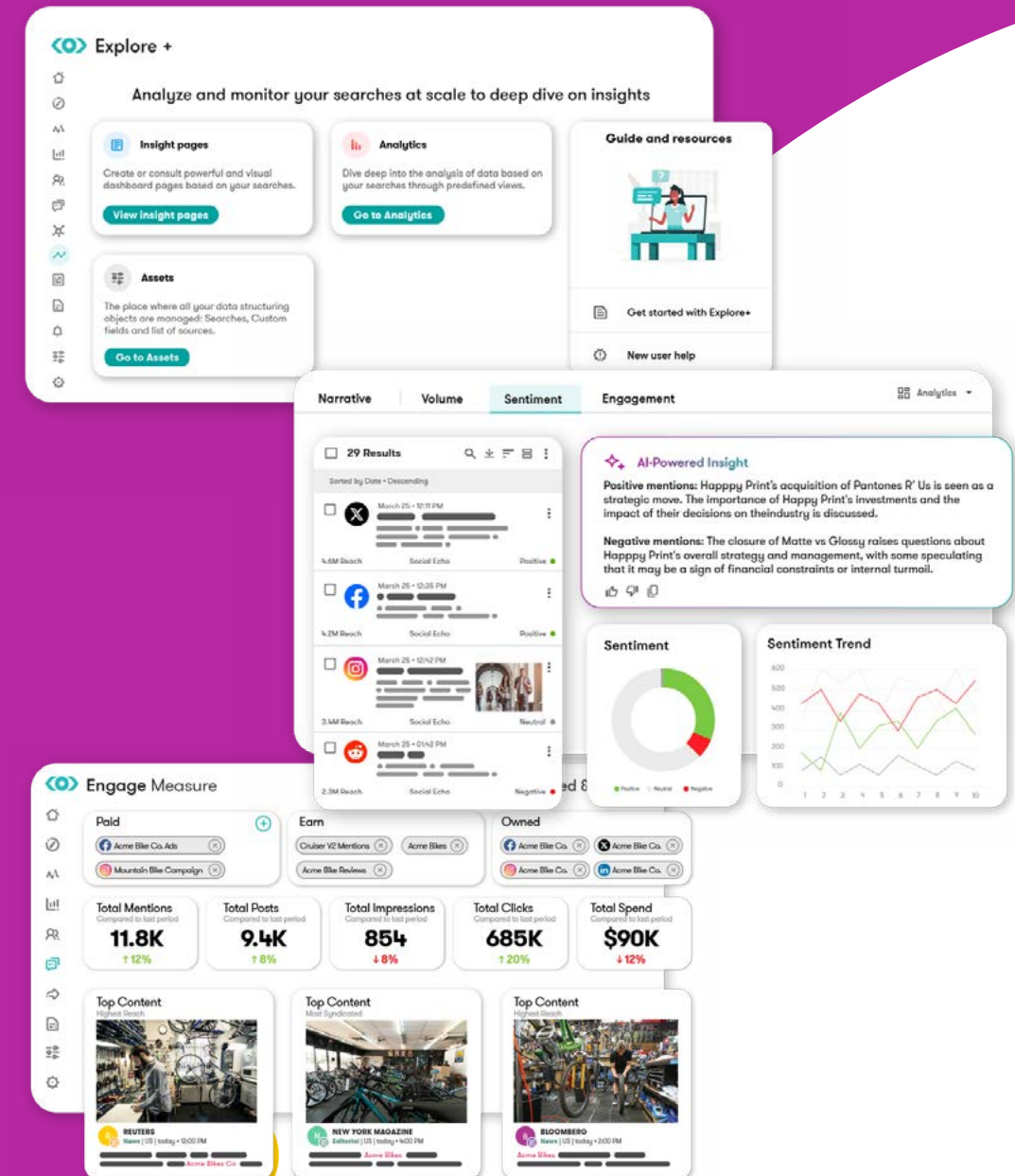
Comprehensive **social listening software**, like Meltwater, can help you see the big picture like never before. By incorporating important insights into your marketing strategy, you can drive more meaningful results, stay attuned to changing industry trends, and monitor competitor activity.

Save your team time with AI-powered insights that process over 1.3 billion social media posts, news articles, and blog posts every day.

With Meltwater, you can focus on what's important, capture the mentions that matter, and uncover the insights you've been missing.

Learn how in a demo with one of our product experts!

[Request a demo](#)



Survey Results: **Social Media**

Social Program Status

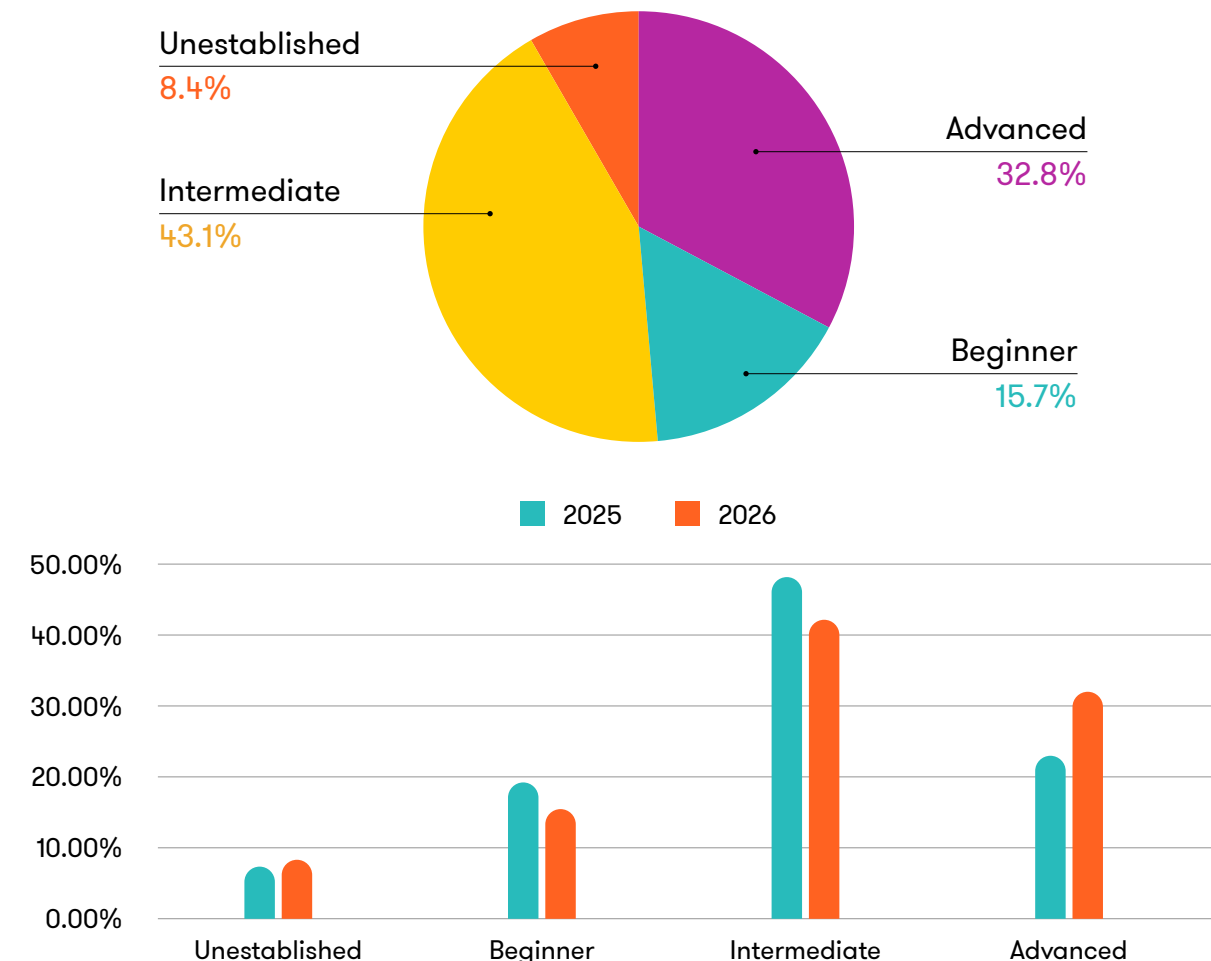
We asked survey participants how they would categorize their social program:

- **Unestablished:** We don't have a dedicated social media team
- **Beginner:** We have a team but are still defining our strategy
- **Intermediate:** We have a strategy but lack the resources needed to execute it
- **Advanced:** We have a full team and strategy mapped out

A small majority (43%) answered “Intermediate,” which echos the previous year, however between 2025 and 2026 we see a much stronger indication that companies in EMEA are taking social more seriously. 32% state their program is Advanced — a 38% increase YOY — and fewer companies are now classifying their programs as Beginner.

It's important to note that “Advanced” doesn't necessarily mean “more personnel”, though that is a fair first assumption. Particularly with the help of AI tools for social, an advanced social program could conceivably be run by one or two people. Check out our [Guide to AI for Social Media Management](#) for ways to optimize social when bandwidth is thin.

How established is your social media program?

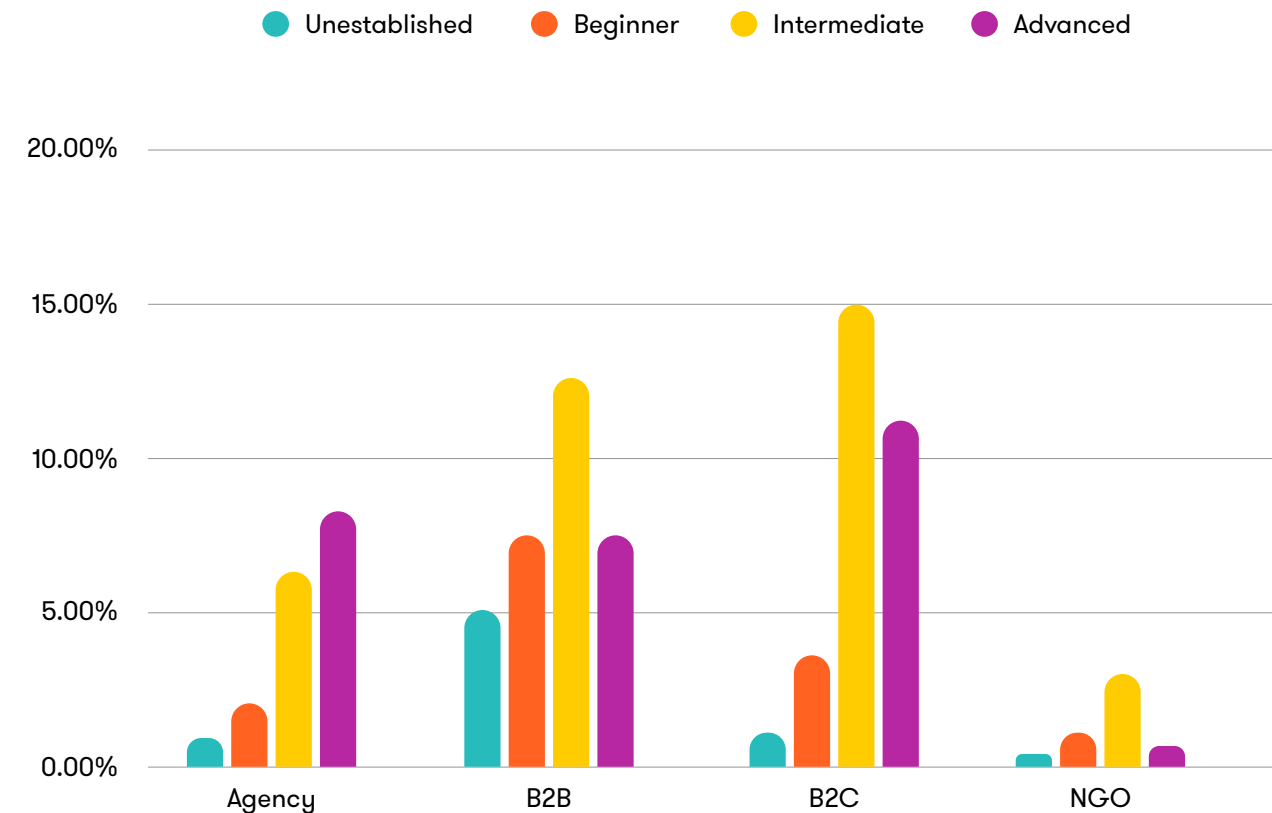


Social program status (cont.)

Breaking it down by company type, B2C companies have the most robust social programs overall, with a combined 26% of respondents classifying their programs as either Intermediate (15%) or Advanced (11%).

These B2C results are understandable, given that social media often acts as a direct sales channel for B2C brands.

By company type

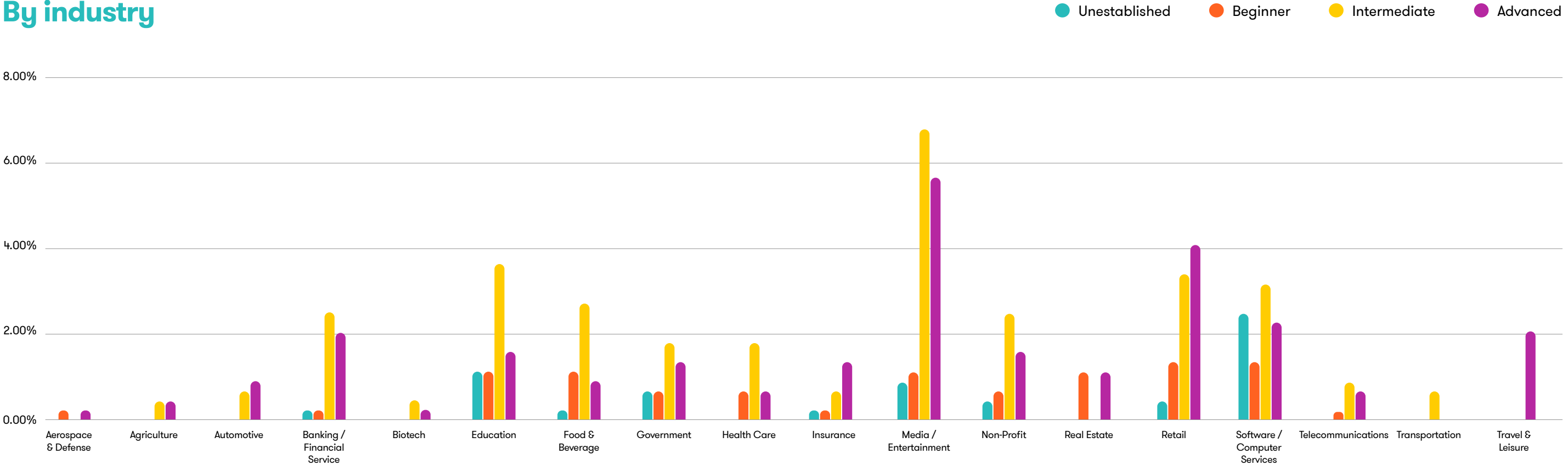


Social program status (cont.)

If we look at social program status by industry, the Entertainment sector leads the way in Intermediate- and Advanced-level social media programs, echoing the global trend. Media companies may be running more intricate social campaigns compared to other industries, and require a more robust approach to cater to wider demographics.

Retail businesses boast the second highest percentage of Advanced programs in EMEA, unlike companies in the Americas, where Education comes in second. As social shopping activities continue to grow, having a strong presence as a retail outfit will certainly be beneficial as companies seek to inspire more sales through social media.

By industry



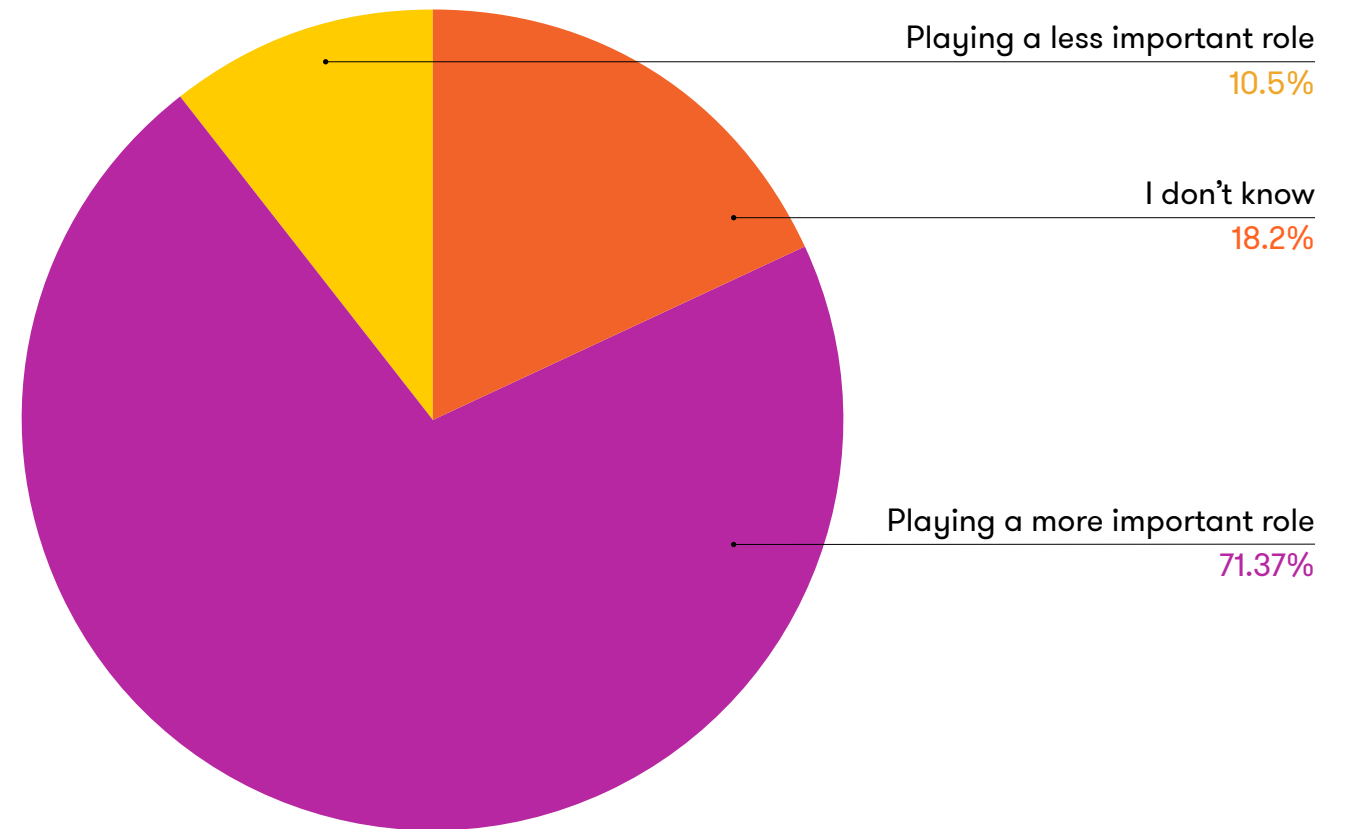
The Role of Social Media in 2025

A majority of companies believe that social will play a more important role in the coming year.

However, we're also seeing a much larger percentage YOY who are expressing uncertainty on the future of their social programs: 18% said "I don't know" regarding how social will develop in 2026 vs. 12% in 2025. This 33% increase demonstrates a significant amount of trepidation on the part of EMEA companies, more than their [Americas counterparts](#). It could be indicative of some unease around what the future holds when it comes to AI or perhaps in response to the continued expansion of GDPR regulations.

This uncertainty is also reflected in how social media budgets will be developing going into 2026.

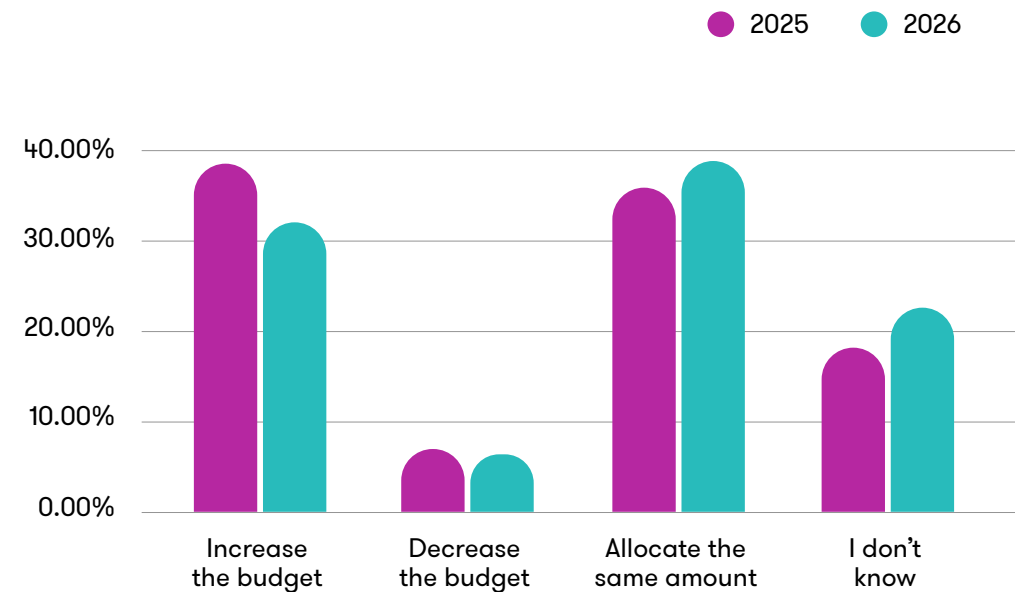
How do you see the role of organic social media developing at your organization in 2026?



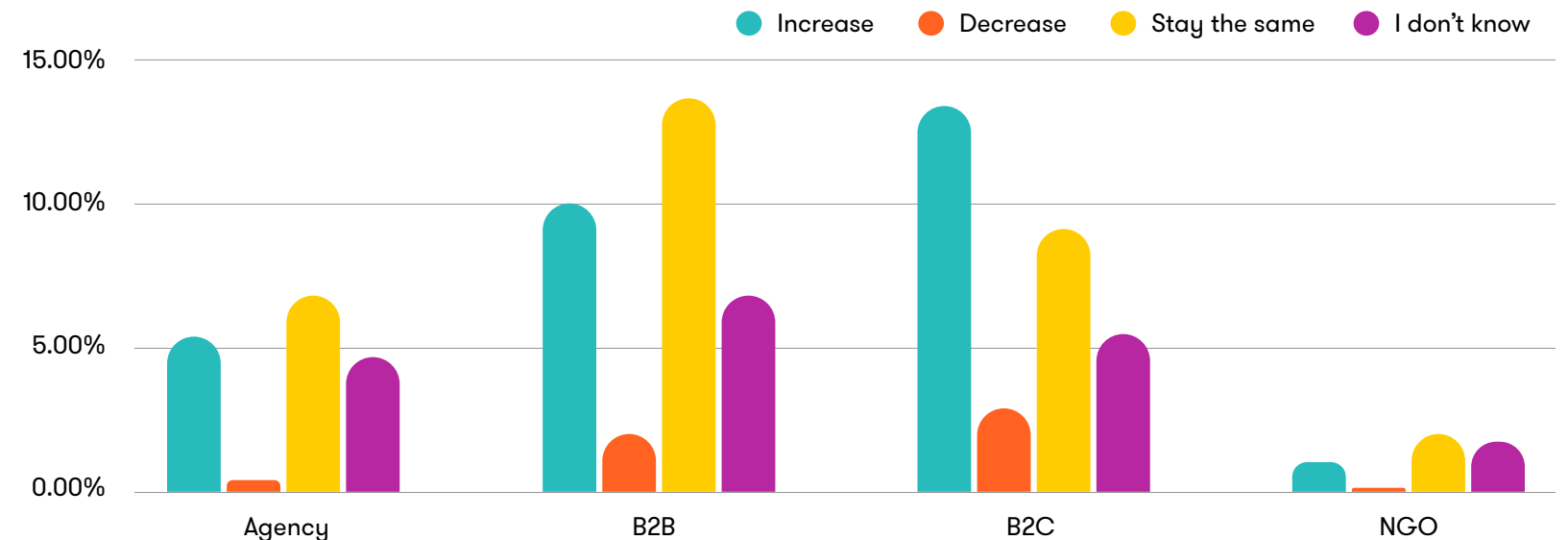
Social Media Budgets

Most companies in EMEA are planning to keep their social media budgets the same in 2026, while 32% are hoping to increase them. However, YOY it's clear that uncertainty about the future of social programs is growing, with 22% stating "I don't know" going into 2026 compared to 18% in 2025. Additionally, more EMEA companies are being cautious about increasing budget YOY. B2C companies have the most aggressive approach, with 13% interested in increasing their social media budgets in 2026, while B2B companies are favoring keeping them flat.

Budget planning YOY



Budgeting by company type



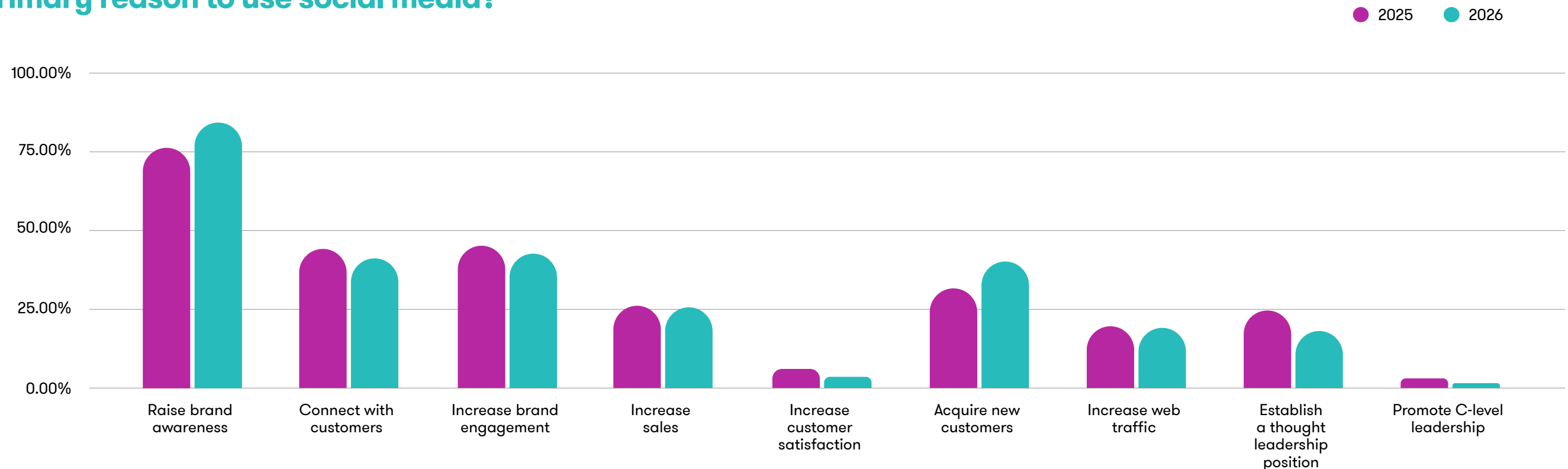
Social Media Goals in 2025

For the third year in a row, we've found that social media's main goal remains getting your brand in front of new potential customers through raising brand awareness.

In EMEA, the second and third most common reasons are tied, unlike in the Americas region where increasing brand engagement is slightly higher than connecting with customers. EMEA also shows the biggest increase YOY in companies keen on acquiring new customers.

In an interesting shift from 2025, more companies will be focused on acquiring new customers in 2026 rather than investing in thought leadership, which shows a decline in urgency YOY.

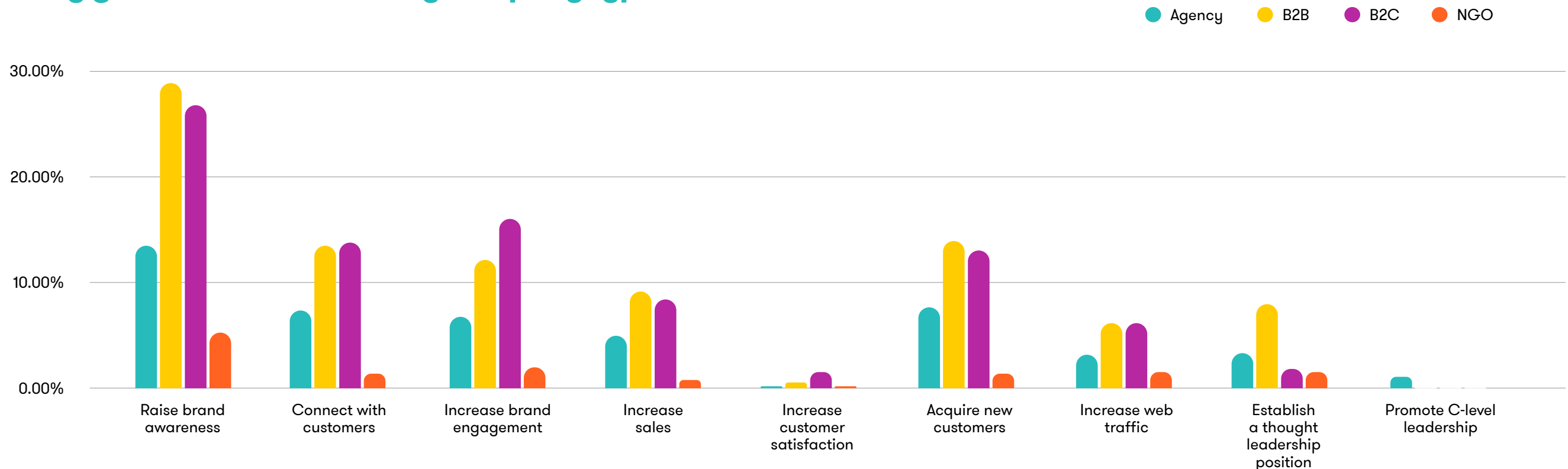
Primary reason to use social media?



Social media goals by company type

Although thought leadership is taking a backseat based on the data overall, when we drill down by company type, it's clear that this is still a key priority for B2B companies. Raising brand awareness and acquiring new customers are also leading priorities for B2B companies, while B2C companies have a clear interest in increasing brand engagement. More and more, we're seeing engagement metrics grow in importance as an indicator of success on social media — partly because they can lead to more budget. More budget means investment in other areas, such as influencer marketing, that help increase awareness and acquire customers — both of which are showing a clear uptick YOY.

Primary goals of social media by company type



Social Program Management

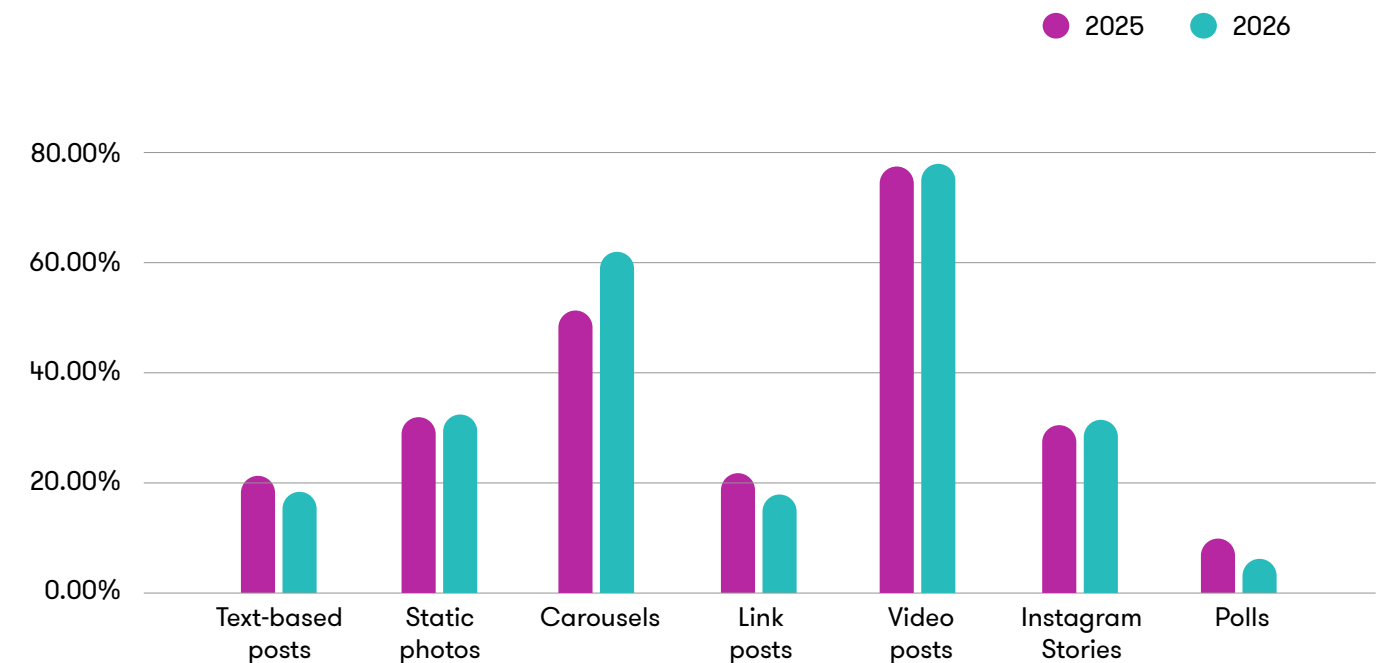
Video continues to be the most popular content format, which aligns with users' evolving viewing habits. Globally, the average user spends **6 hours and 39 minutes** each week watching short videos such as Reels or TikToks, and **4 hours 51 minutes** per week enjoying longer form video content.

([Global Digital Report](#))

Compared to the [Americas region](#), EMEA companies are more interested in using Instagram Stories for social media marketing.

Carousel posts have jumped in popularity, increasing by 20% YOY. Carousels have been available on Instagram for many years, and they are a common approach on LinkedIn. A static slideshow format has also been an option on TikTok since 2022. The platform has been encouraging creators to utilize this feature, favoring them on the coveted FYP and claiming that photo posts can garner more engagement.

Which content formats are you prioritizing for social?

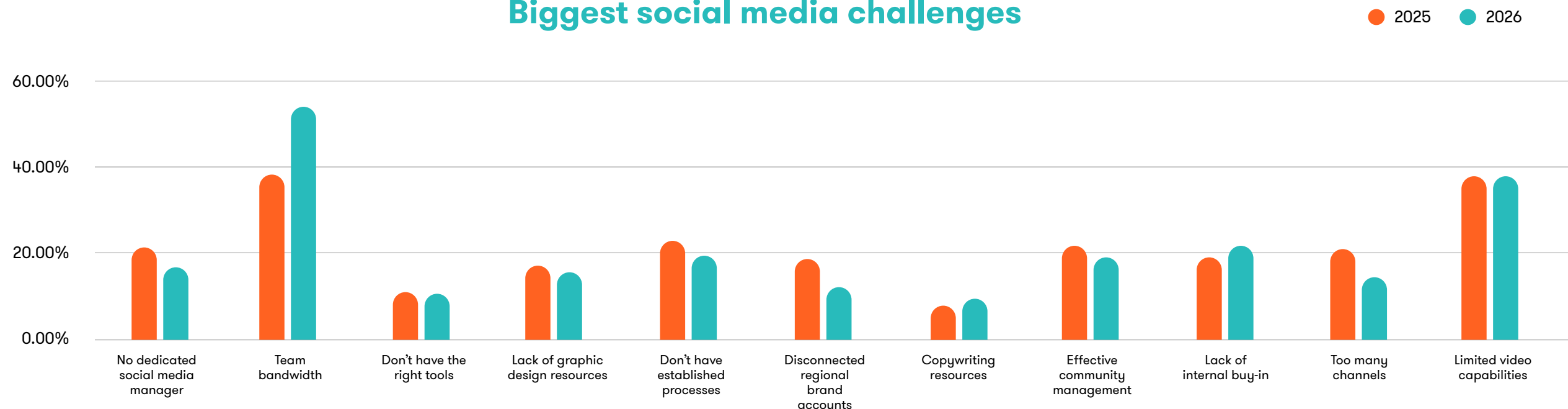


Social Media Challenges

When it comes to the roadblocks preventing social media growth and engagement, most companies agree that team bandwidth is the biggest obstacle. Companies in the EMEA region are more concerned YOY about bandwidth (up 29%) than their counterparts globally (up 11%) and in the Americas (down 11%).

The second biggest struggle is limited video capabilities, though it has stayed at the same level of concern YOY, rather than growing like we see in our global findings. Another discrepancy in EMEA is the challenge of gaining internal buy-in, which sees an increase YOY, unlike companies in the Americas region, where it decreased. Again, marketing leadership in EMEA may be feeling cautious about expanding social media programs due to GDPR restrictions. This is despite the fact that social media usership is actually **higher in the EMEA region** compared to the Americas region.

Biggest social media challenges



3 compelling reasons to invest in video

Wondering which challenge to prioritize addressing this year? Even though static imagery still has its place, the importance of video content cannot be understated. Here's why:

- **39% of internet users worldwide watch how-to videos or educational content**

Opportunity: Promote subject-matter expertise from your company with videos that answer user questions. Leaning into brand authority and proficiency is also a commonly recommended tactic for GEO. By demonstrating unique brand-led data and in-depth content, you can improve your LLM presence and information accuracy.

- **52.5% of internet users listen to podcasts each week**

Opportunity: Podcasts are not just audio-only anymore. Many creators also film the recording and post snippets to TikTok or the full video to YouTube, offering users more choice as to how they consume their favorite media. Consider starting a company podcast to strengthen your thought leadership program and grow brand awareness.

- **On average, users spend 1 hour 37 minutes on TikTok per day, seeking out funny or entertaining content**

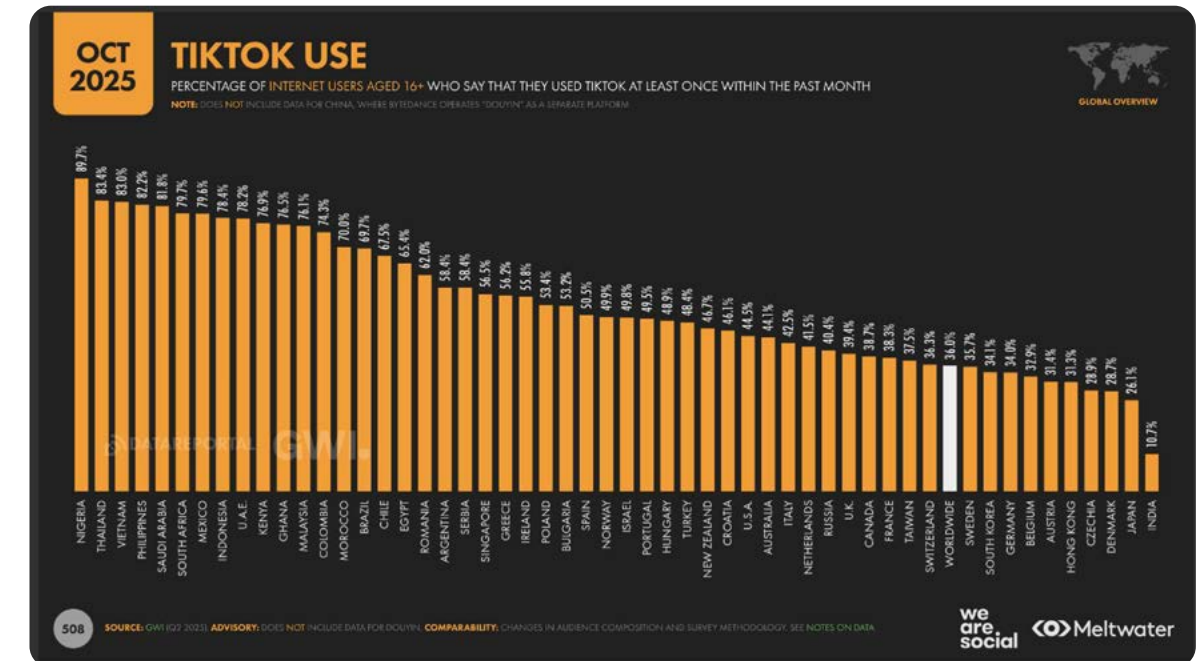
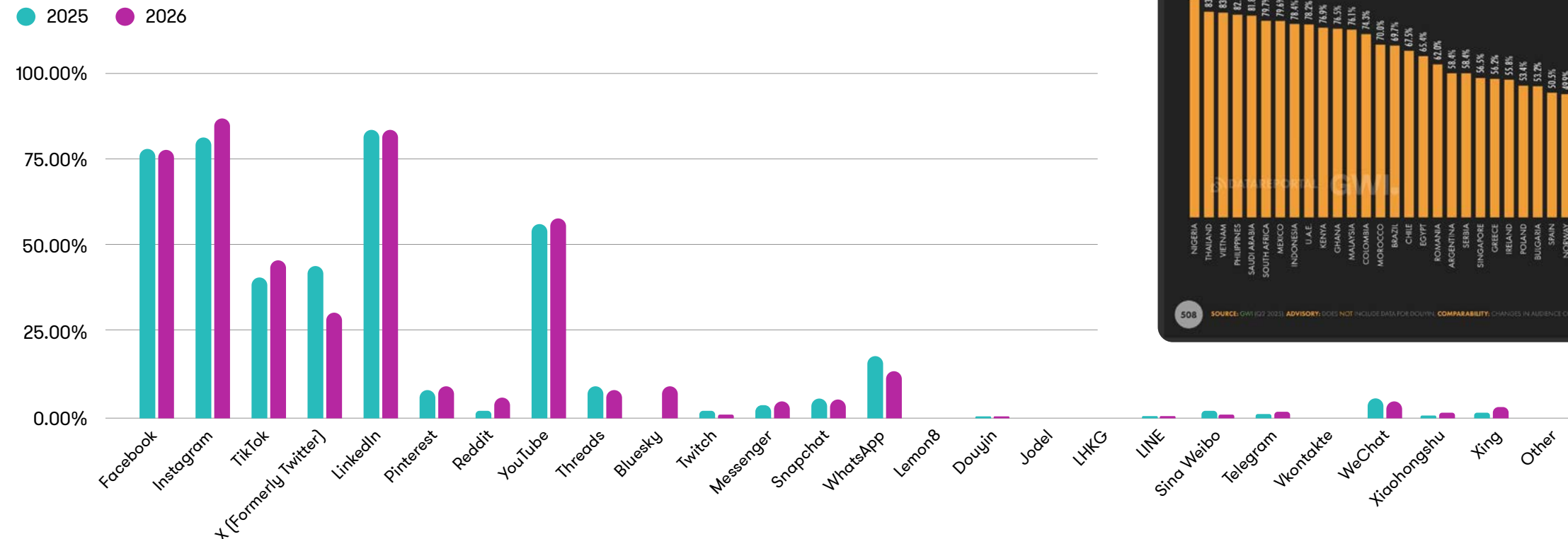
Opportunity: Take advantage of TikTok trends and popular audios. Remember that TikTok is a space where unpolished, authentic content thrives. No professional video set up? No problem. All you need is a smartphone and some willing participants to start establishing a TikTok presence. Lean on your younger co-workers to understand the trends — don't dismiss them.

Channel Usage

The most popular channel used is Instagram, which shows a strong lead, increasing by 6% YOY. Unlike companies globally, where LinkedIn usage dropped by 7% YOY, companies in EMEA show a consistent interest in this channel.

TikTok shows a 12% increase, which is quite a bit lower than companies in the Americas market, where interest in TikTok grew by 28%. **TikTok activity in Germany is lower than the global average**, which could contribute to these results. Nearly a quarter of EMEA survey responses came from Germany, so companies there may be using TikTok less robustly for their social marketing activities.

What channels are you currently using for social media?



High Priority Platforms

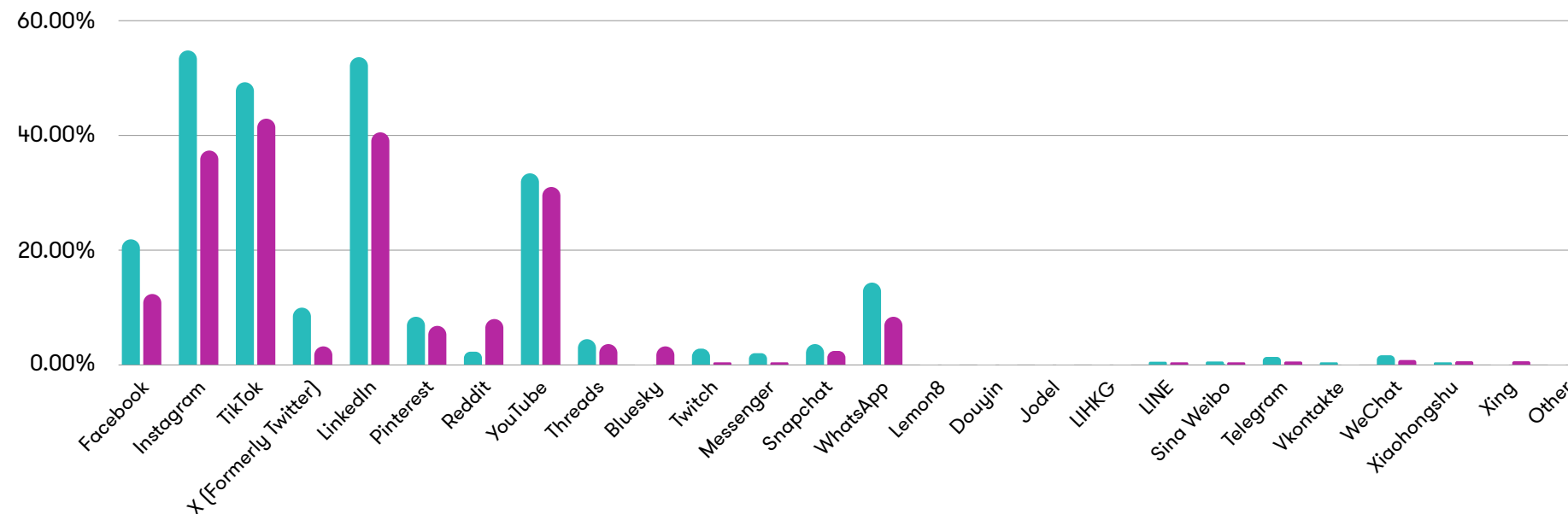
TikTok in EMEA may not currently reflect as high a usage as companies in the Americas, but that could change — the platform surged ahead of both Instagram and LinkedIn this year to become the top priority channel in EMEA going into 2026. A clear indication of the channel's importance for achieving social media success.

The growing interest in the platform is led by B2C companies and, unlike the global trend, B2B companies in EMEA are not expressing any interest in pursuing the platform further in 2026. In fact, interest has dropped by 46%. EMEA companies may want to rethink this approach, however, given that their peers globally are investing heavily on TikTok. And they have plenty of incentive to do so: the platform shows a **17.6% increase YOY in ad reach** (1.9 Billion), and business accounts see roughly a 5% engagement rate.

Similarly to Americas companies, we are seeing a surge in popularity for Reddit YOY. We have more analysis on the Reddit phenomenon on page 26!

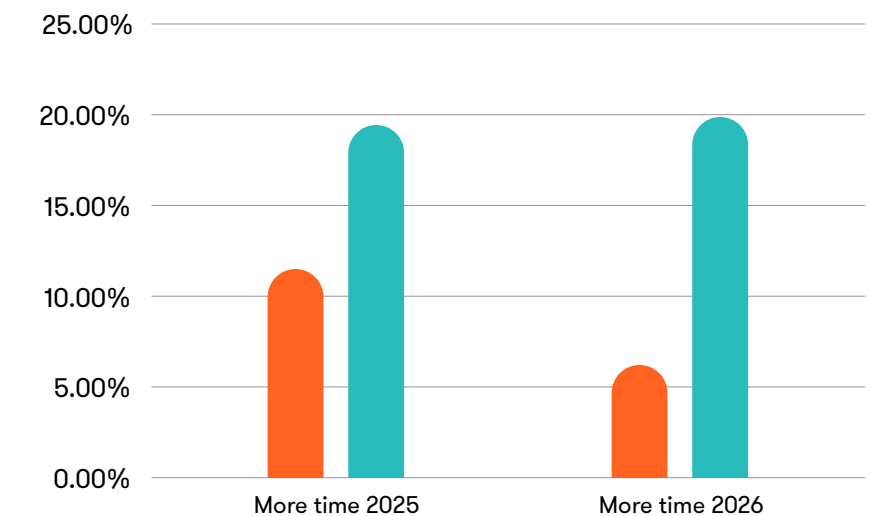
Where are you planning to spend more time in 2026?

● 2025 ● 2026



Interest in prioritizing TikTok

● B2B ● B2C



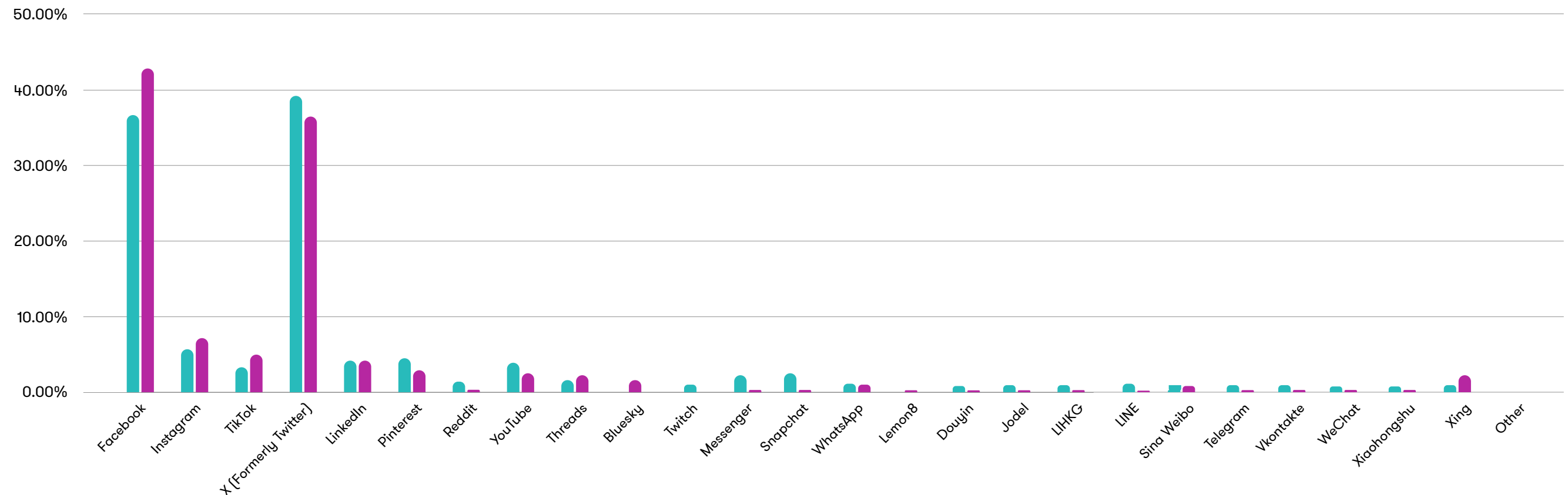
Low Priority Platforms

Across the board, Facebook and X are the two platforms that companies express less interest in focusing their efforts on in 2026, echoing the trend from the previous year. EMEA companies, however, are more aggressive in their desire to move their attention away from Facebook with a 16% increase YOY, compare to a 9% increase globally.

Before continuing to de-prioritize Facebook, however, businesses should consider the fact that the platform has actually seen a [5.7% increase in reported ad reach YOY](#).

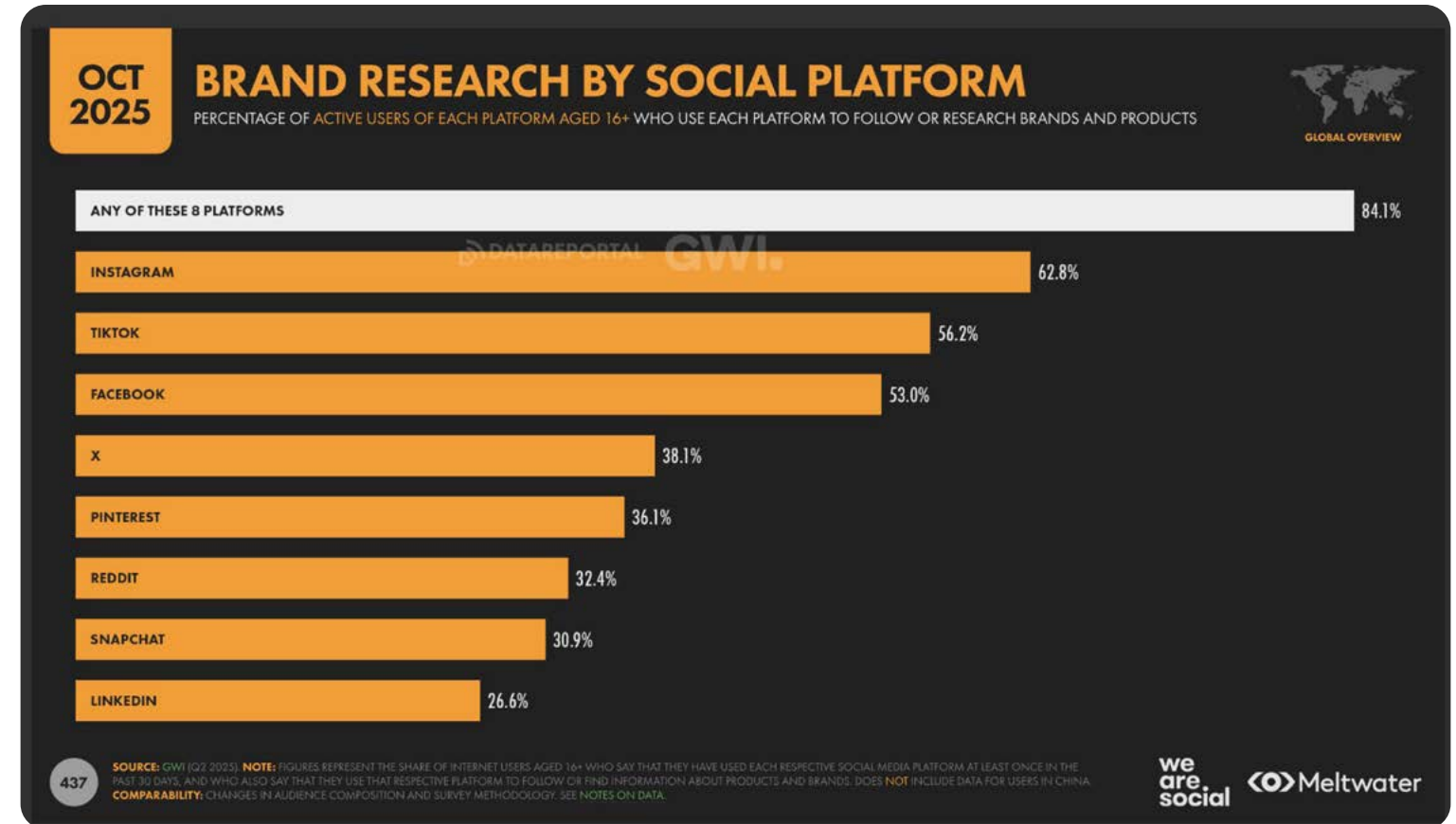
Where are you planning to spend less time in 2026?

● 2025 ● 2026



Where does the most brand research take place on social media?

As we mentioned in the intro, [72% of internet users](#) conduct brand research on social media, looking for information that influences purchase decisions. When it comes to the top platforms for this kind of research, Instagram, TikTok, and Facebook lead the way — another reason to consider rethinking the de-prioritizing of Facebook.

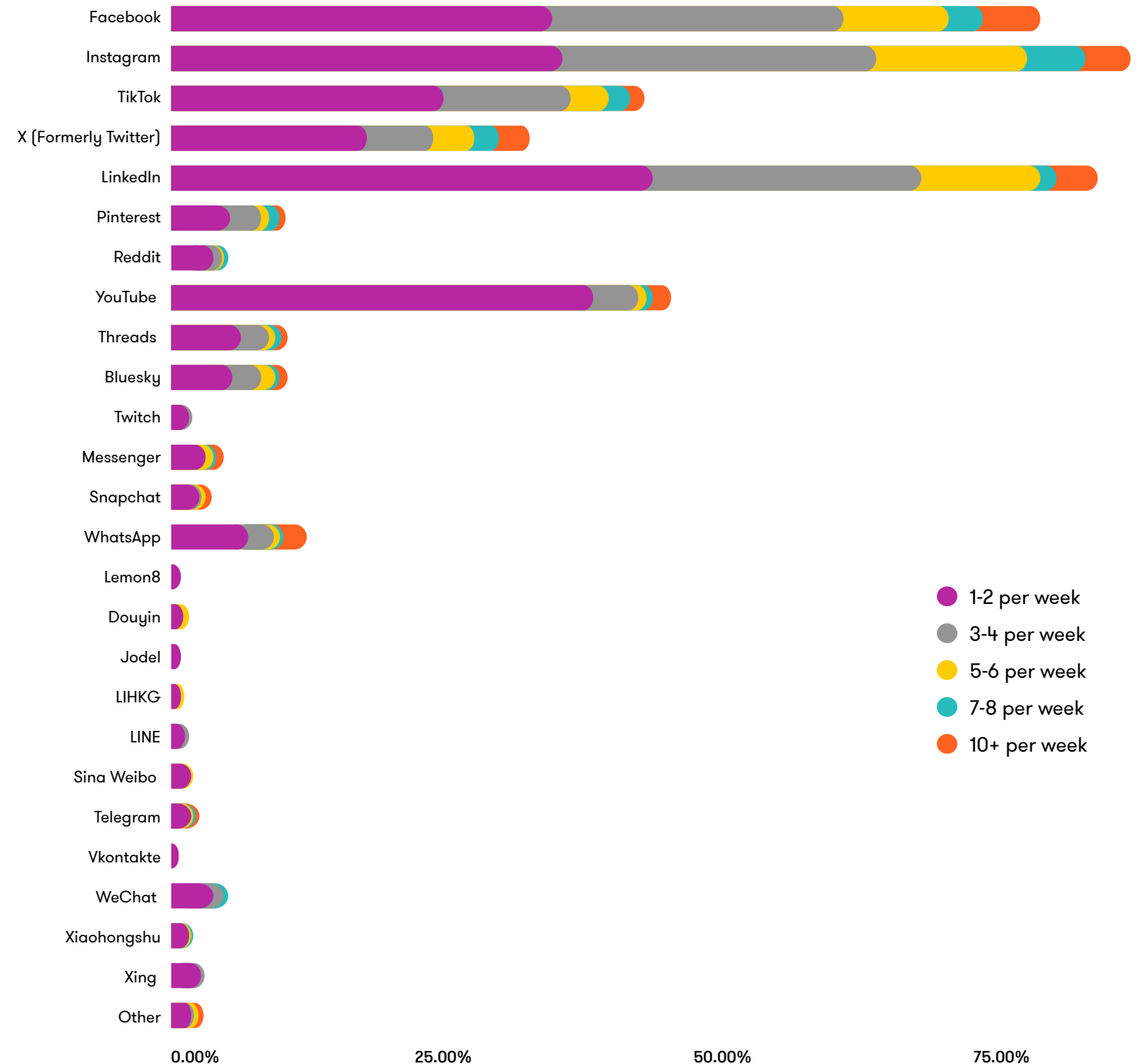


Posting Cadence & Priority

The platforms with the most activity are Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn, X, YouTube, and TikTok.

LinkedIn is much more popular in the EMEA region, with 43% posting 1-2 times a week as opposed to 37% globally.

Compared to companies in the Americas, WhatsApp is showing more popularity among EMEA companies. Only 2% of Americas companies post on WhatsApp 1-2 times per week, compared to nearly 7% in EMEA, a 15% increase YOY. According to the [Global Digital Report](#), WhatsApp use is higher than the global average in many EMEA countries, including Germany and the UK — which account for half of State of Social Media survey respondents.



Posting cadence & priority: **Reddit**

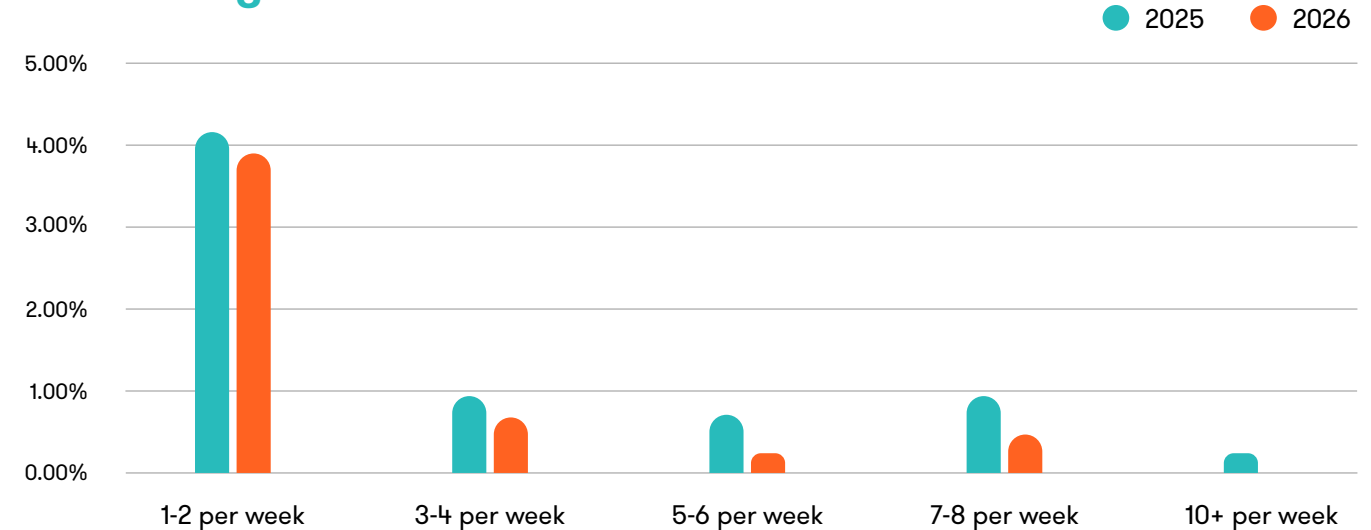
Unlike teams in the Americas, Reddit usage in EMEA has not grown YOY, but as we saw earlier, it is slated as a high priority platform going into 2026. The industries currently using Reddit the most include Entertainment, Software, and Food & Beverage.

Reddit's strong presence in LLM results, and ability to influence consumer behavior both in-app and from an SEO perspective, is clearly catching on.

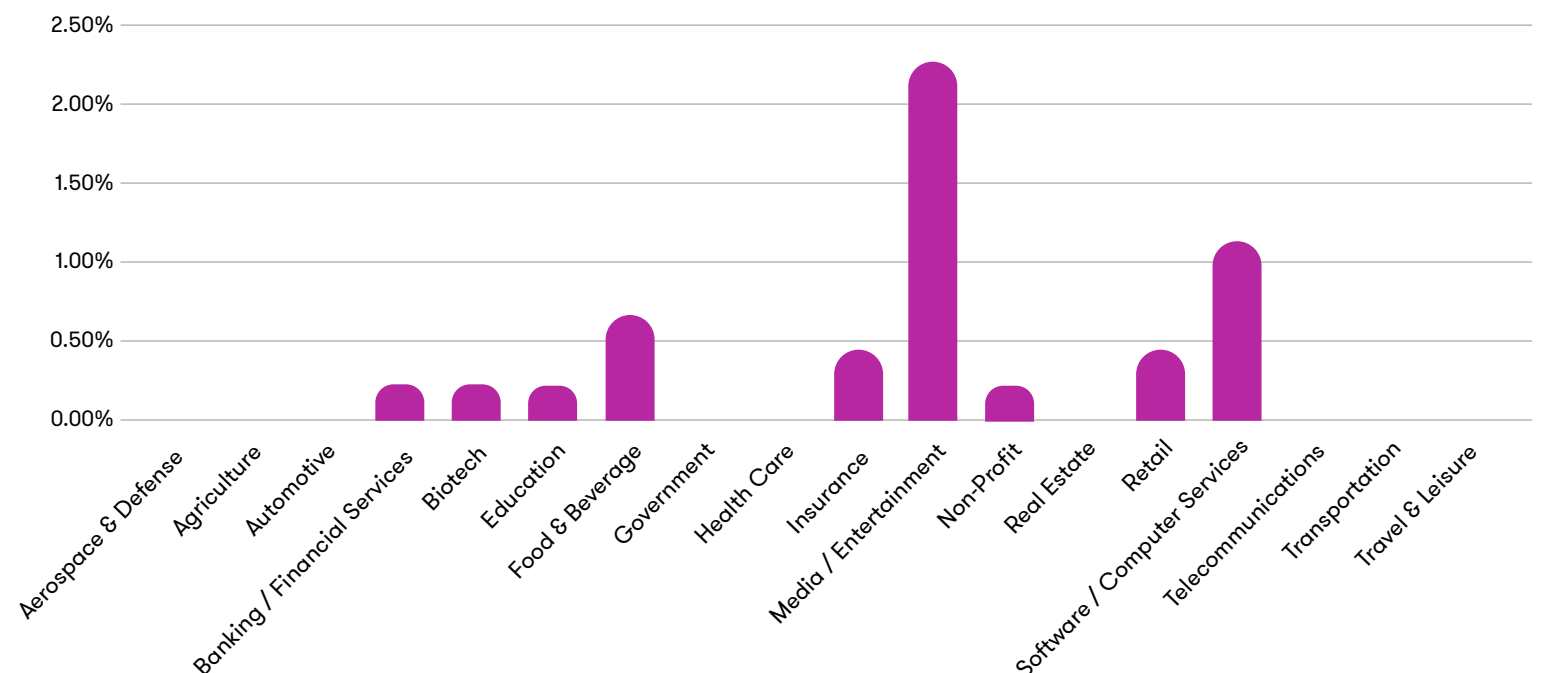
And for good reason. According to the [2026 Global Digital Report](#):

- Potential ad reach on Reddit is 765.2 Million. That's up YOY by 189%!
- People spend an average of 19 minutes per day on Reddit, which is indicative of its powerful use-case as a search engine result.
- Reddit is the second most popular social platform for researching brands or products, behind Pinterest.

Reddit usage in EMEA



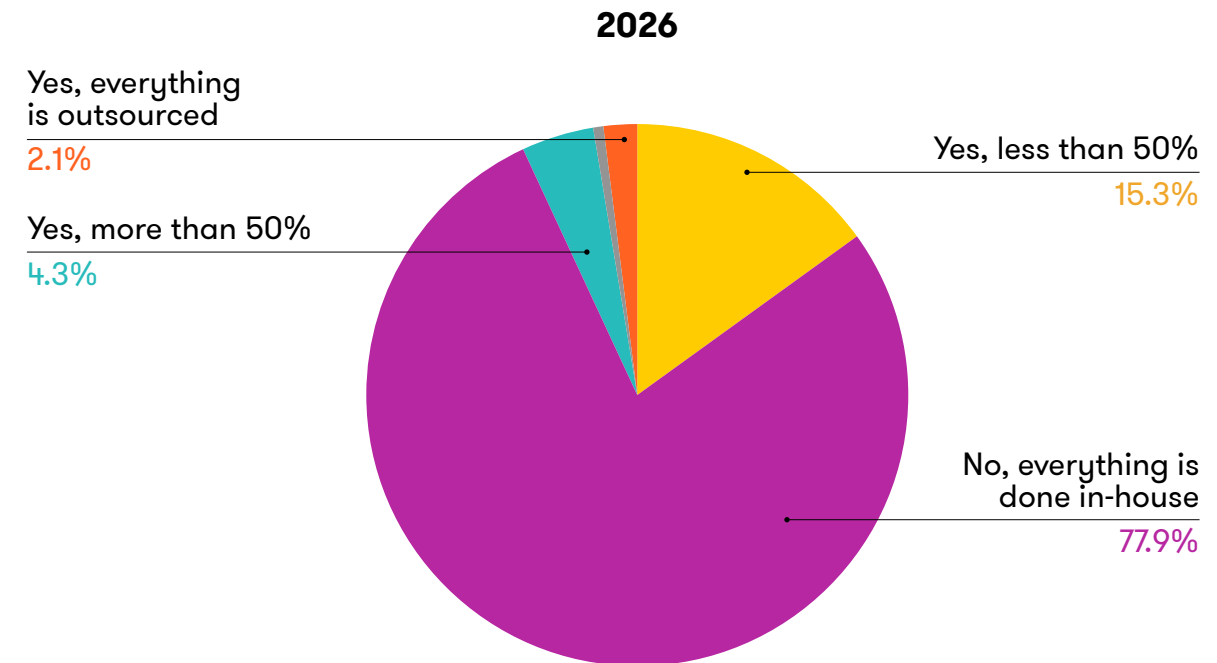
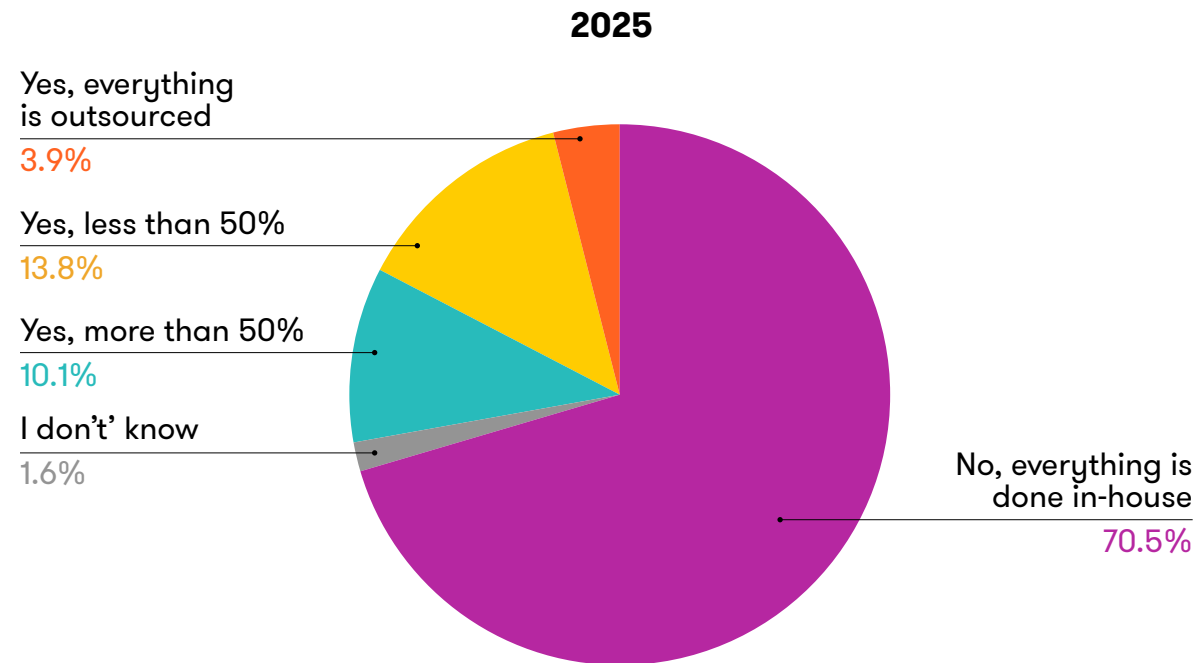
Reddit use by industry in EMEA



Outsourcing vs. In-House Social Management

There is a significant YOY increase (+10%) in the number of EMEA companies bringing their social media management entirely in-house. This follows the global trend and could be indicative of a need to divert budget elsewhere. Additionally, companies may be finding that with AI solutions, smaller social teams can handle a wider range of activities in-house than they used to.

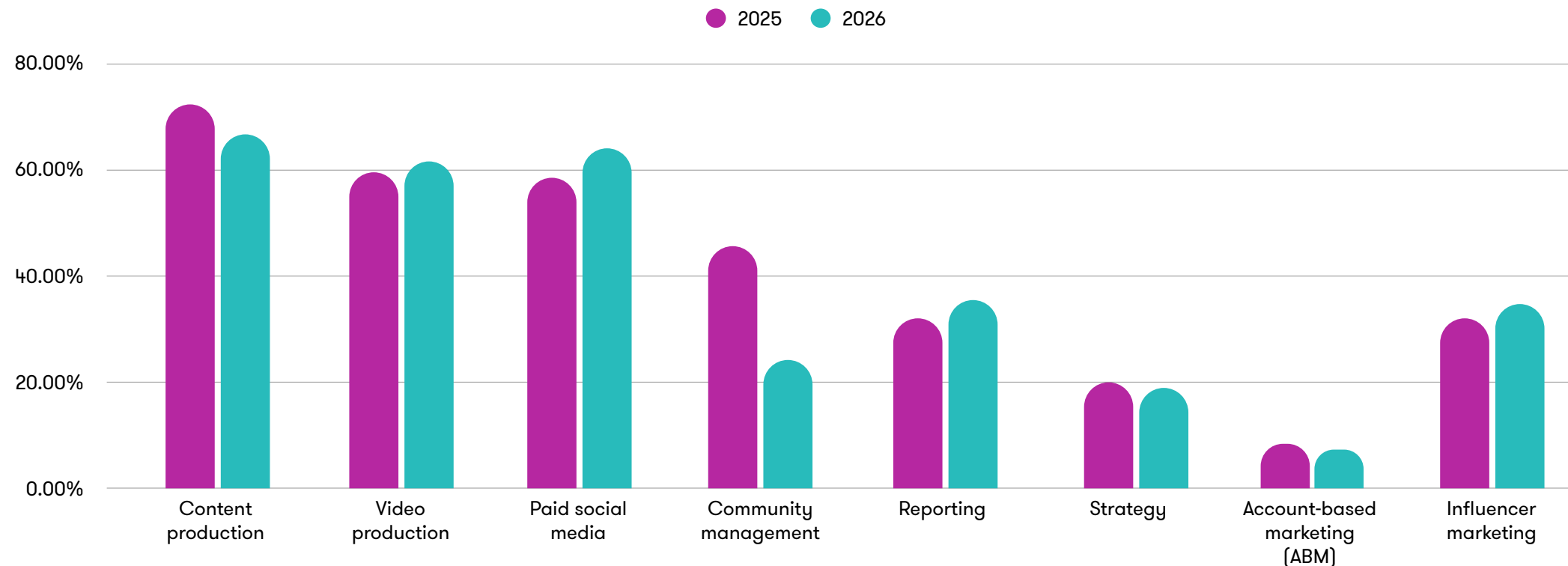
Do you outsource the management of your social media channels to a third party or agency?



Services Outsourced

Of those companies that do outsource, EMEA companies are focused in most of the same areas as their [Americas counterparts](#): content production, including video, and paid social. Paid social in particular has jumped in importance with an 8% increase YOY. Contrary to those in the Americas region, there is a significant drop (-47%) in the number of EMEA companies outsourcing community management services. There could be a number of reasons for this, but an interesting one to consider is the heavy move toward DM communication among social media users (or “Dark Social”), which makes traditional community management harder to implement and scale.

What services do you outsource?



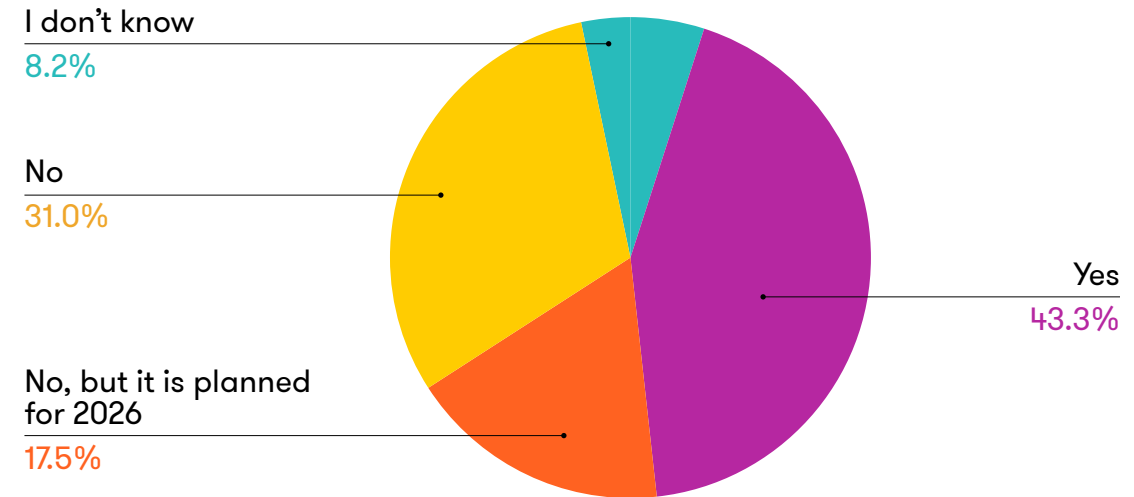
Survey Results: **Social Listening**

The Role of Social Listening

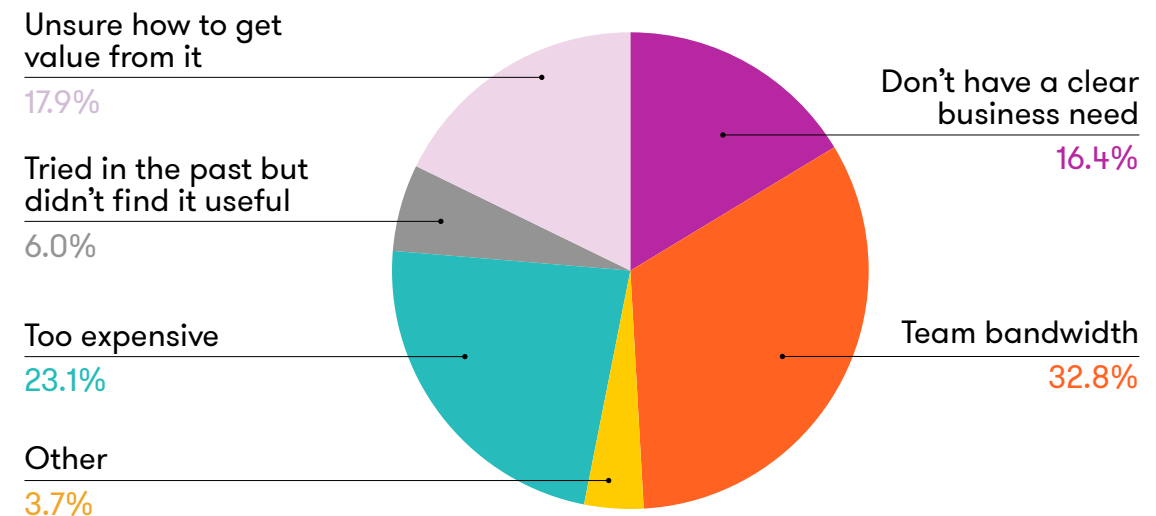
10% fewer companies in EMEA say they have a social listening strategy in place this year.

Compared to the Americas, more EMEA companies are set on exploring social listening in 2026, though regionally the number is down 20% YOY. Of those who aren't currently using it, team bandwidth is the biggest issue, followed by cost concerns.

Is social listening currently part of your organization's social media marketing strategy?



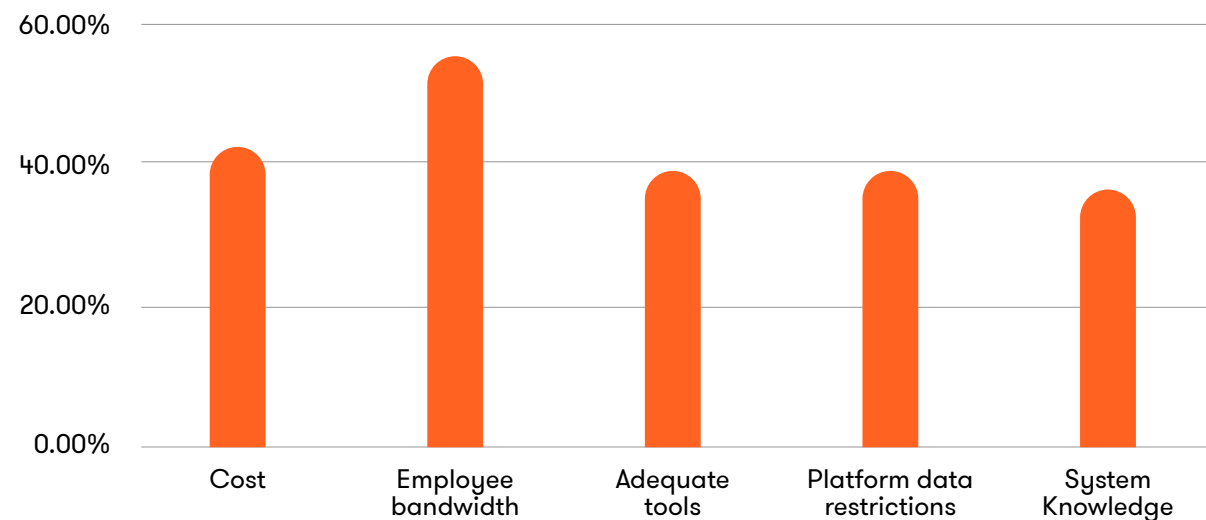
Why are you not currently using social listening?



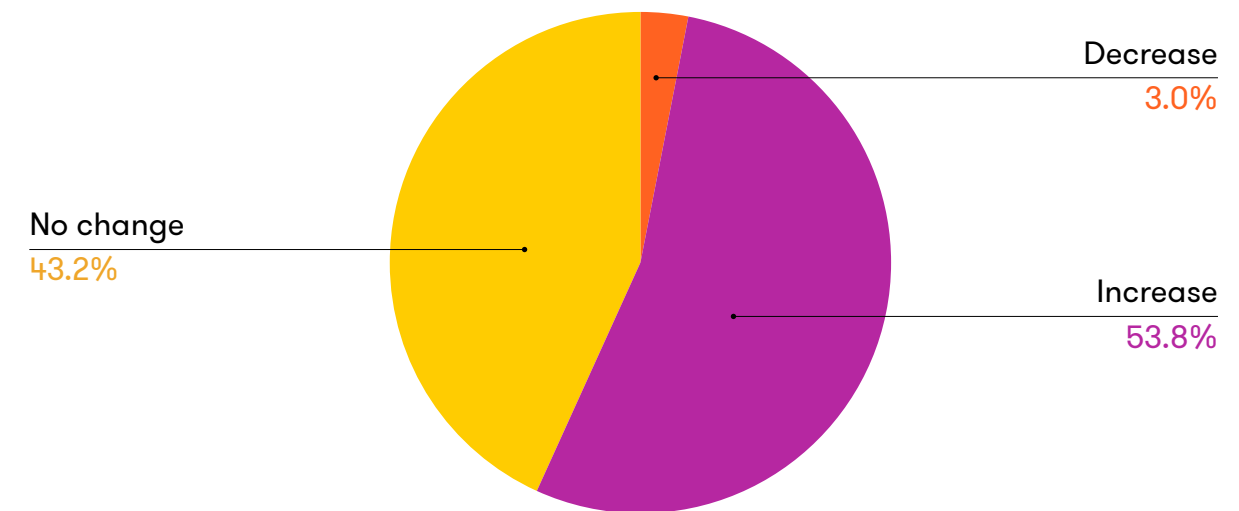
Investment in Social Listening

Companies in the EMEA region are certainly feeling more cautious heading into 2026 when it comes to investing further in their current social listening activities. 43% state that they expect no change, up 10% YOY. While this could indicate that their current strategy is yielding satisfactory results, more likely they lack the manpower and financial means to expand, as the data shows.

Which factors would you consider the most restrictive in terms of maximizing your use of social listening?



Do you expect to increase or decrease your social listening resources in 2026?

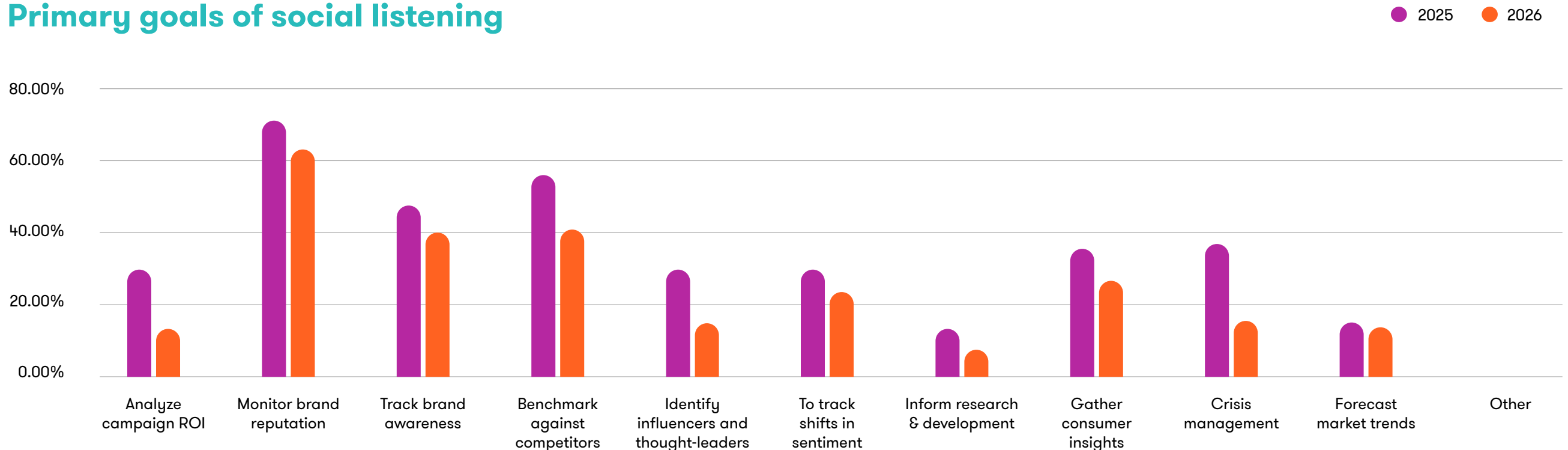


Why Companies Use Social Listening

There are numerous advantages to social listening, but monitoring brand reputation is the top goal for 63% of EMEA marketers. Social listening allows for faster crisis response and enables brands to more effectively manage areas of reputational risk, as well as reinforce positive aspects by diving into the nuances of customer conversations to understand public perception.

This leads us to the 38% who say they use social listening for tracking brand awareness, the second most popular goal. Social listening allows you to get a real sense of market permeation. By benchmarking against industry topics and competitors, gathering and analyzing consumer insights, and tracking shifts in sentiment you can create a strategy based on facts — skipping the guesswork and moving forward with data-backed decisions.

Primary goals of social listening

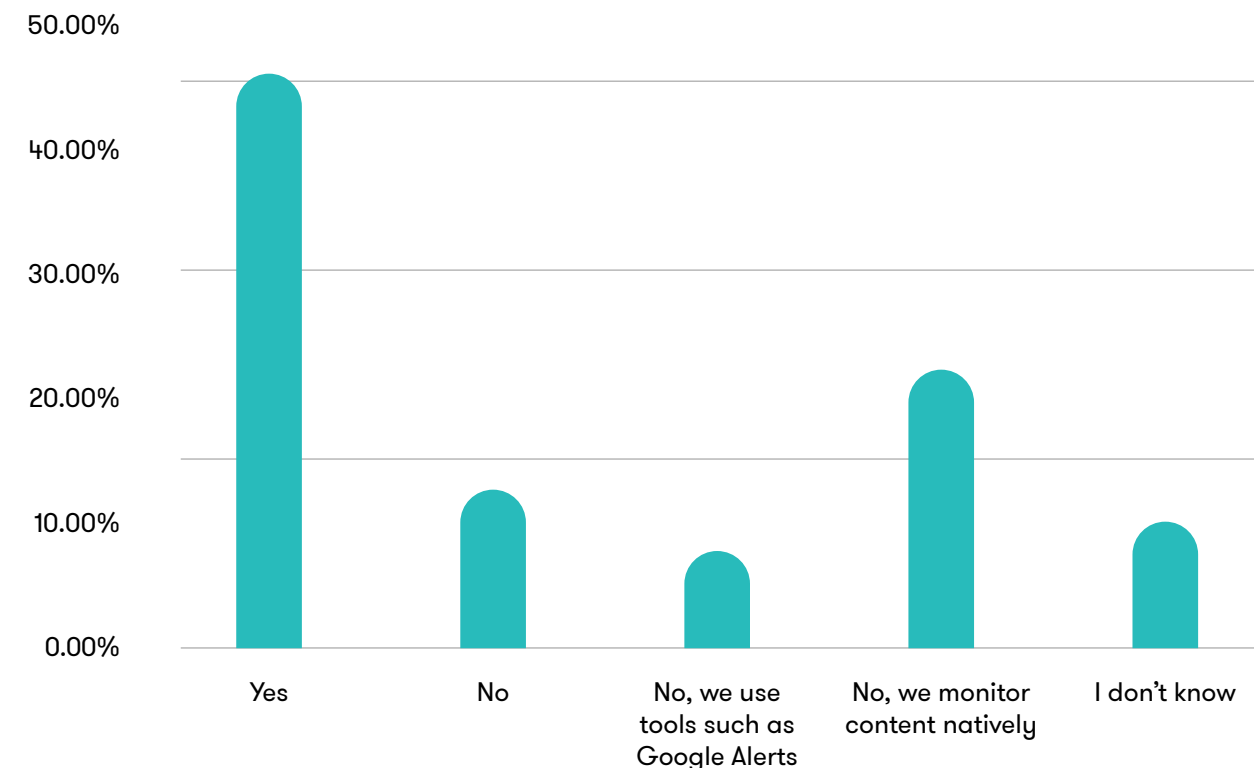


Ways of Conducting Social Listening

There are a number of ways that social listening can be conducted, though a software solution is the recommended route for the most comprehensive overview of your brand health, sentiment analysis, audience activity, industry conversations, and competitor benchmarking. Of the respondents that already leverage social listening, software is the preferred method. Interested in learning more? Check our [Definitive Guide to Social Listening](#) or the [Social Listening for Benchmarking Guide](#)!

Those who use other means tend to prefer to monitor natively rather than using tools like Google Alerts, consistent with last year's responses.

Are you using or planning to use social listening software?



Get the full digital picture

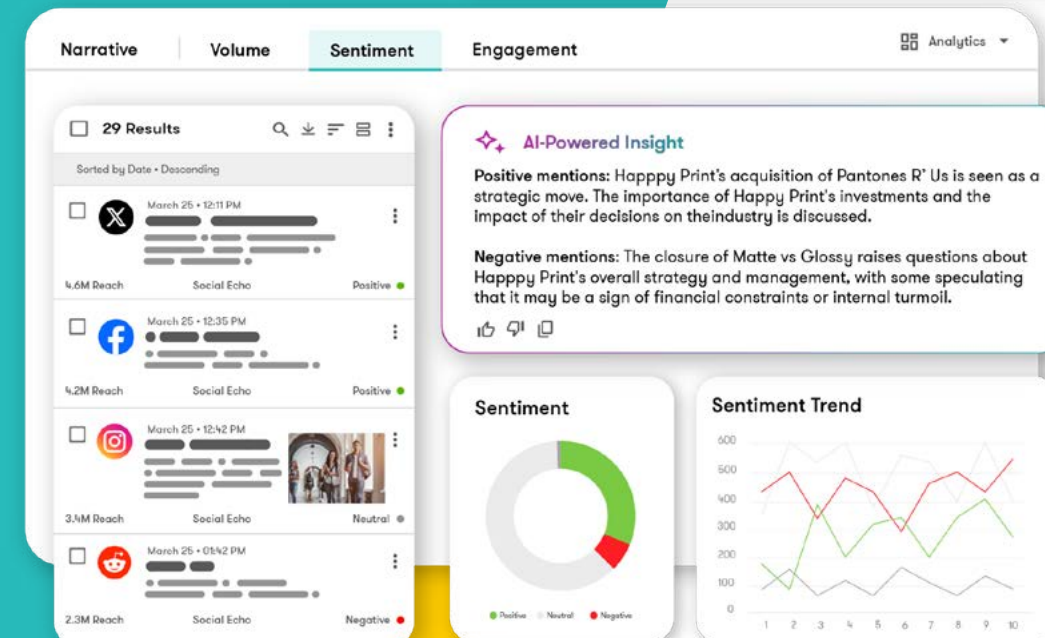
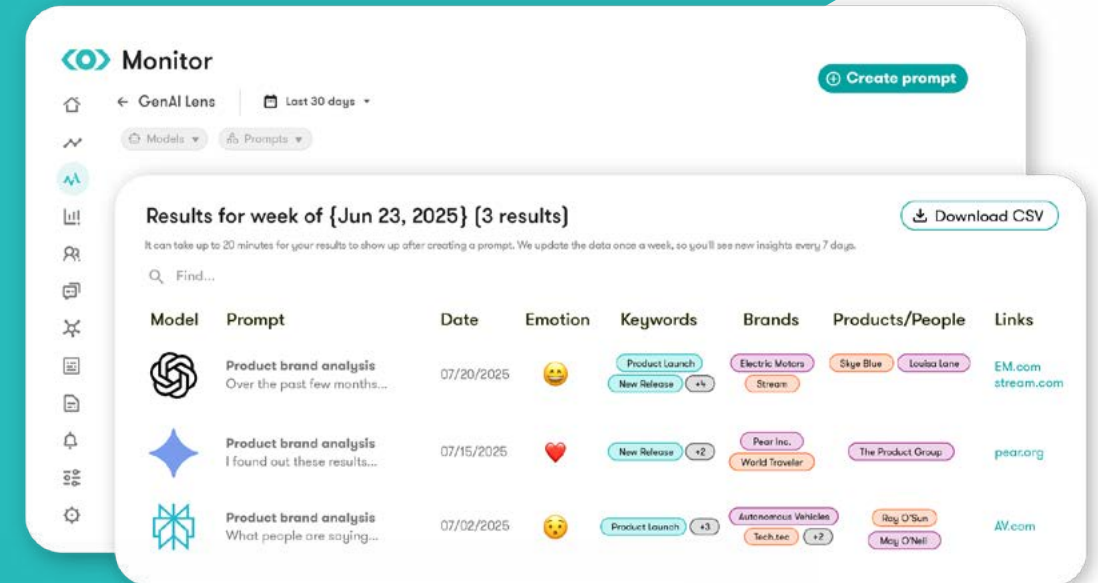
The clear growing desire to monitor brand reputation could speak to the growing uncertainty around how your brand is showing up in LLM results.

With **Meltwater's GenAI Lens**, you can leave some of that uncertainty behind and gain greater visibility into your brand presence on LLMs, including the sources that these AI assistants pull from when delivering outputs about your company.

See inside the black box of LLM search and ensure that you're safeguarding your brand reputation in this rapidly growing channel. Access comprehensive social listening coverage, real time alerts, sentiment analysis, and more with Meltwater.

Learn how in a demo with one of our product experts!

[Request a demo](#)

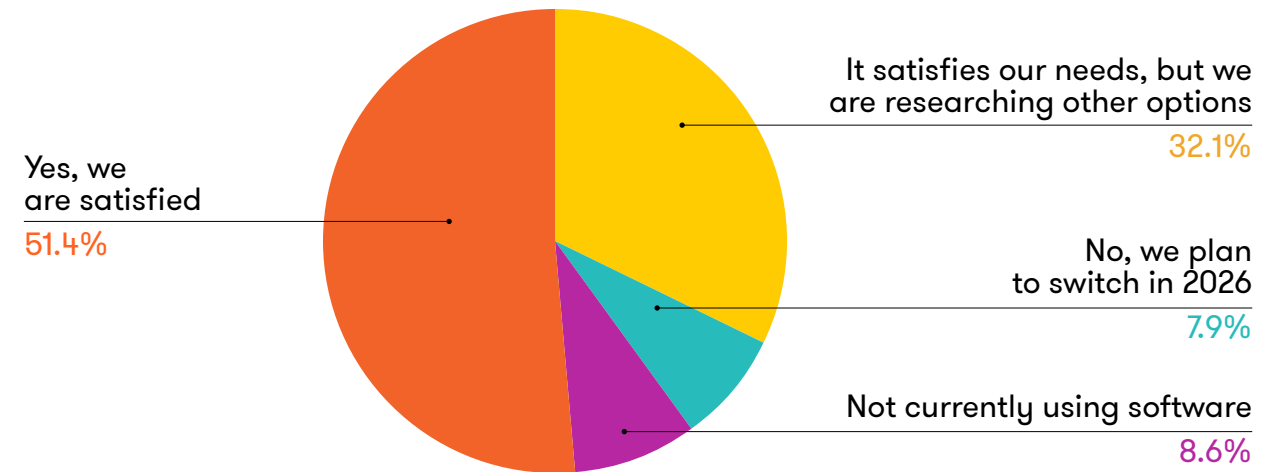


Effectiveness of Social Listening

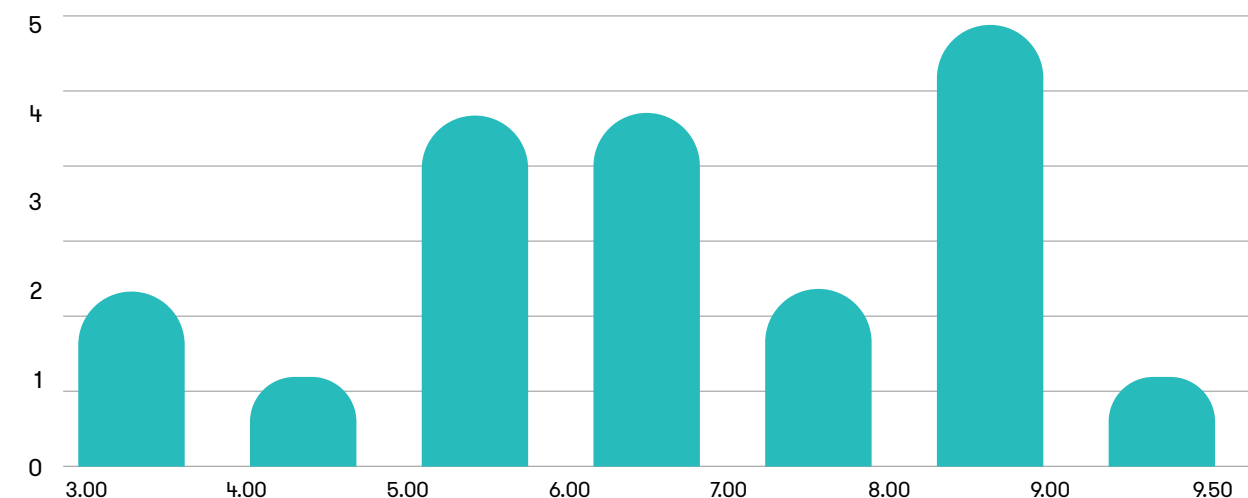
While monitoring natively can certainly yield some insights, it's far too time-intensive and susceptible to human error. Who can keep up with thousands of alerts on a daily, or even weekly, basis? Plus, the capabilities are limited, so gaining deeper insights and analysis is far less available when employing native social listening efforts.

Going into 2026, 14% fewer survey participants said they are satisfied with their current software solution, while 32% are intent on researching other options — the same YOY. Most have average levels of confidence that they are using those capabilities to the fullest extent.

Are you satisfied with your current social listening software?

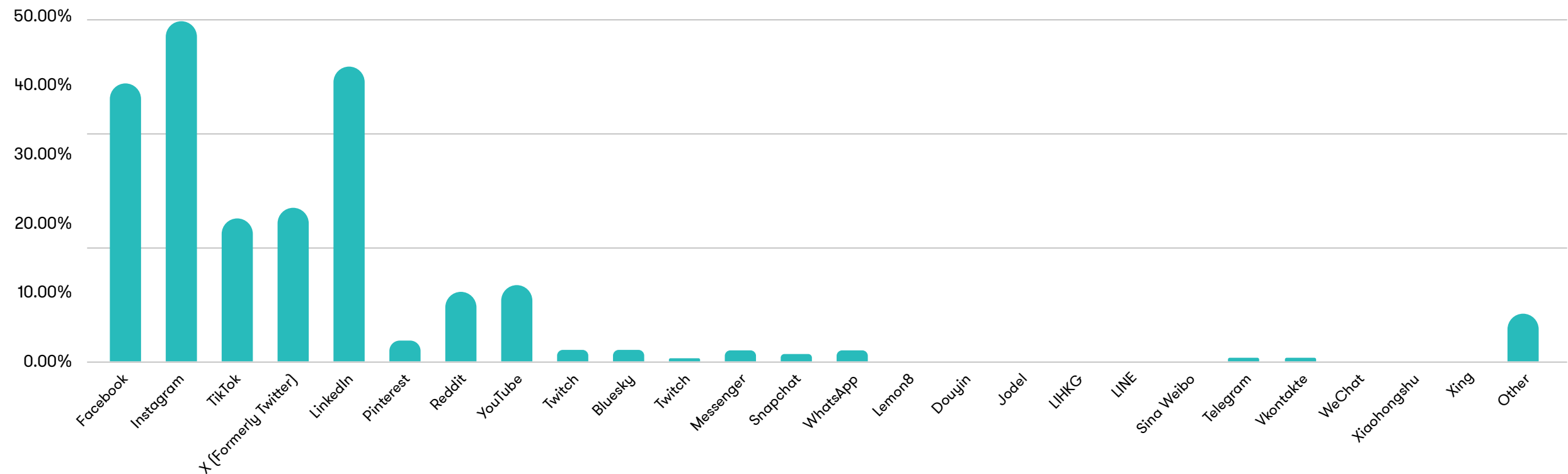


On a scale of 1 (not confident) to 10 (very confident), how confident are you that you're using social listening capabilities to the fullest?



Best Platforms for Native Social Listening

According to our EMEA survey respondents, these platforms have the best data for natively tracking and gathering social listening insights. Instagram shows the biggest increase YOY, surging further ahead of Facebook. In 2025 there was only a 4% difference, but as we go into 2026, the gap has grown by 26%.



Customer Story: Neuro

As a science-driven company producing functional gum and mints for elevated mental clarity and focus, Neuro relies on strong data to do everything from developing products to building brand identity. It leveraged Meltwater's social listening solution as one of its tools to analyze the market and strategically target relevant audiences. The insights gleaned from Meltwater inspired 406% YoY sales growth and 1B+ impressions across all channels.

“We really wanted to figure out how to get the right audience segmentation data in a cost-efficient way. We landed on Meltwater social listening because it's an accessible way to garner insights within the energy management category.” Jennifer Chang, VP of Commercial and Head of Marketing at Neuro.

Neuro used Meltwater to analyze the market, mapping out target audiences based on opportunity size and relevance to the energy management category. Through that data, the brand identified the top incremental audience segments it needed to capture, which included gamers — validating an existing assumption and allowing them to pursue lucrative partnerships within that sector.

Ready to get started using Social Listening on your team? Schedule a demo with one of our product experts

[Request a demo](#)



406% YoY sales growth
driven by Meltwater insights

1B+ impressions
across all channels

Survey Results: **Paid Social**

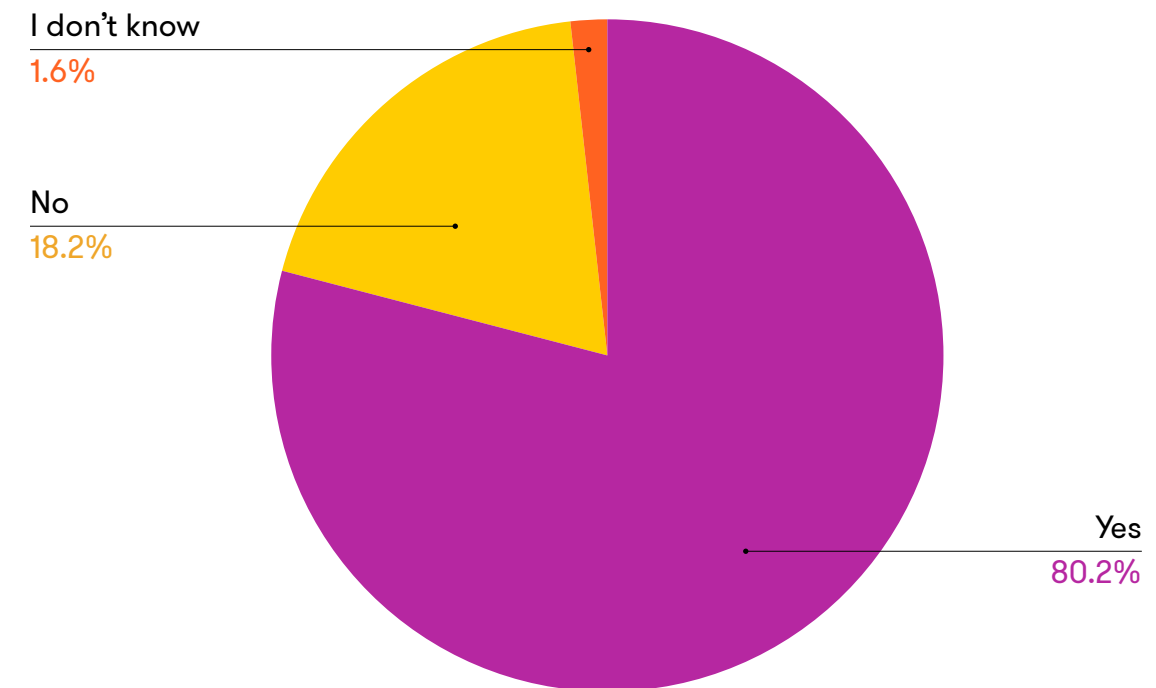
Paid Efforts On Social Media

A slightly higher number of companies in EMEA (+2%) are investing in paid social media than their counterparts in the [Americas region](#).

Digital ad spend as a whole is growing exponentially, reaching \$862 billion in 2025 — a 9% increase YOY. ([Global Digital Report](#))

Paid advertising and boosted posts on social are a great way to increase your reach and get in front of relevant audiences who might not be aware of your brand, goods, or services. In fact, **30.4% of internet users discover brands through ads on social media.** ([Global Digital Report](#))

Does your business run social media ads?

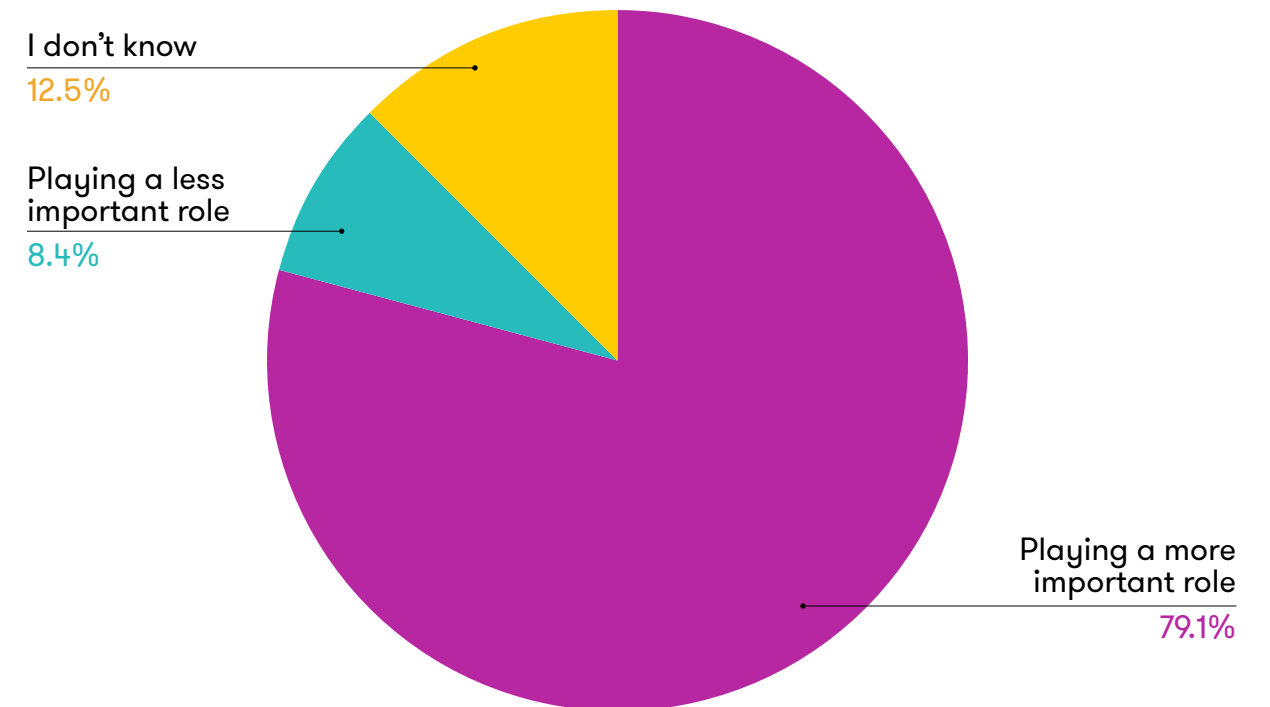


The Role of Paid Social in 2026

Most businesses in EMEA are planning to either increase their investment in paid social media or keep it the same.

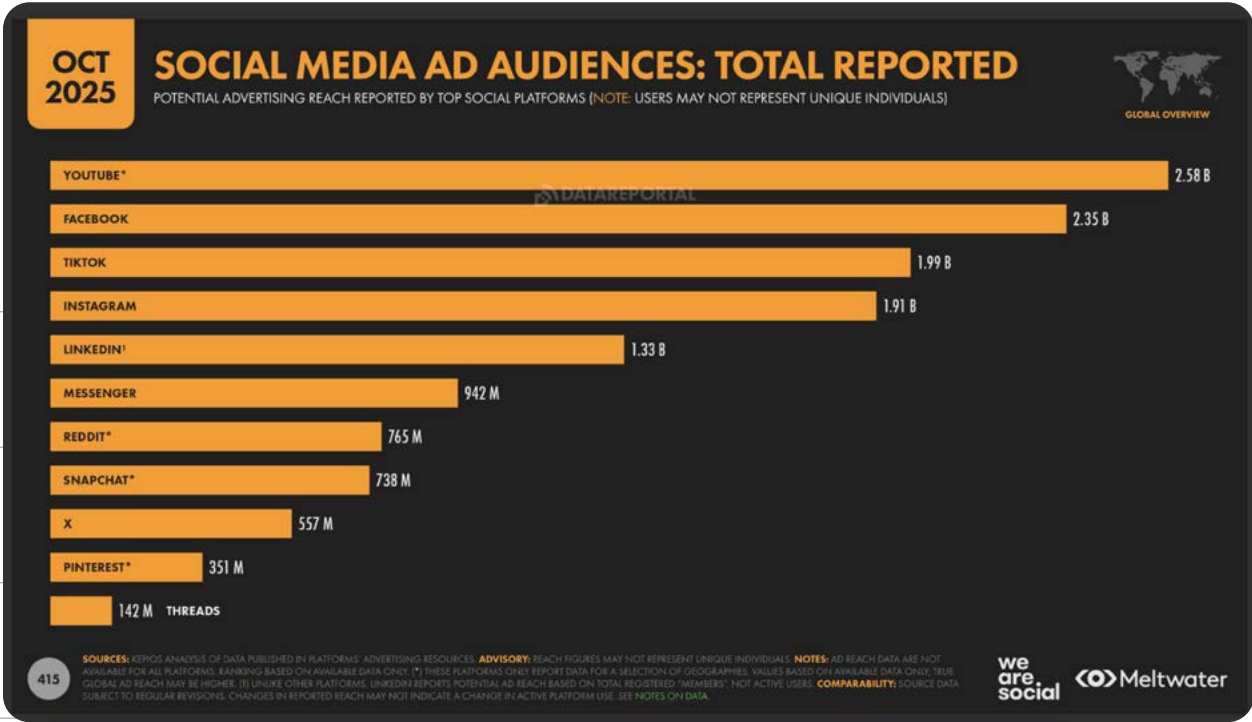
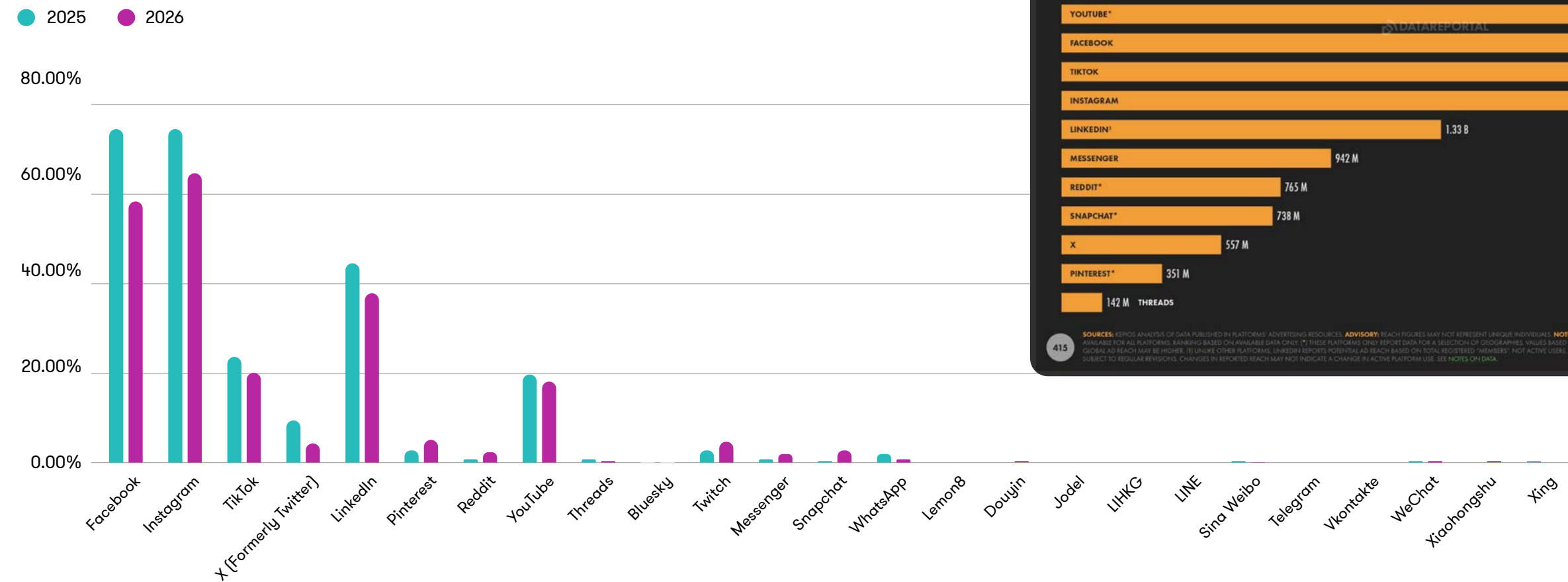
This year, a slightly smaller percentage than we saw going into 2024 (8% vs. 10%) indicate that they think paid efforts will be less important in the coming year. Given this trend, social media teams may want to assess the resources they are allocating to paid in order to stay competitive on social media.

How do you see the role of paid social developing in 2026?



The Biggest Players In Paid Social

Instagram, Facebook, and LinkedIn see the most activity in EMEA when it comes to paid social media. According to the [Global Digital Report](#), the platform offering the most potential ad reach is YouTube, followed by Facebook and TikTok.



Conclusion

Looking ahead to 2026, the trends show more companies in EMEA being cautious about increasing budgets and expanding their social programs but there are also clear signs of aspiration:

- There's a 38% increase in companies who have Advanced social programs
- Customer acquisition as a goal for social media is up 28%
- TikTok usage is up 12%
- More companies YOY are bringing social media management in-house

What does this mean for you? You peers are starting to see value in TikTok, so maybe it's time to put more energy into your strategy there. Consider also that with a greater focus on customer acquisition, you may want to ensure your brand awareness goals align (or stand out with a non-sales oriented approach to social).

Let the data from this report help you determine key areas for developing and improving your social media strategy in 2026.



Use social listening and consumer insights to learn more about your audiences preferences.

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